



Introduction

Golden Mask Verse is organised into focused chapters, each designed to stand on its own. Read cover-to-cover or jump to whatever catches your eye first.



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CHAPTER 1

Name the First Crack

Dead Router Sunburn

Why does my Wi-Fi die right when the sun hits my face?

The blue light on the router goes from brave to broke.

I press the WPS button like it owes me rent.

Nothing.

My phone screen keeps spinning like a lazy ceiling fan.

The sun don't ask permission.

It lands on my forehead in a hot slap.

I taste pennies - copper breath, cheap cologne, panic.

My shadow starts acting different, like it got its own agenda.

"Come on," my mouth says, but my voice sounds far.

The feed won't load, the beat won't buffer, the world won't line up.

Static crawls in through the cracks:

hiss like a snake doing housework,

hiss like a cassette eating itself,

hiss like a crowd that forgot my name.

I check the signal bars - like counting stitches on a ripped shirt.

Two bars, then one, then nothing.

My hands sweat through my wristband anyway.

Tanya - nineteen - community college DJ - I feel the term "offline" hit like a bruise.

My playlist sits there, smug, refusing to move.

My thumb hovers over "retry" like that's a prayer.

The sun burns harder when I get mad.

Light turns mean.

Heat makes everything sound closer.

Even the silence.

Then the static leans in, whispering back:

not words - just proof.

A backtalk hiss that says, *you're still here.*

A backtalk hiss that says, *you can still count rhythm without a signal.*

I breathe through my teeth and listen.

The router stays dead.

The sky stays loud.

And the static keeps talking like it's got receipts.

What's the first crack in the wall - the moment the Wi-Fi cuts out,
or the moment you realize your mind was leaning on it for cover?

Sun On Tongue

The sun hits my face like a spotlight with no stage.

I squint so hard my eyes start arguing.

My phone says "No Internet" in a font that feels personal.

I set the volume knob anyway.

Not for the Wi-Fi - for the anger that needs a drum to ride on.

Static shows up with a cigarette cough.

It rides the speaker like it paid for entry.

A hiss that turns into syllables only my jaw understands.

I hear my own heartbeat in the noise floor.

Thump - pause - thump - like a metronome that got tired of being polite.

"Don't freeze," I tell myself, low.

My voice comes out brittle.

I try to talk over the hiss and the hiss wins.

The sun keeps pressing my skin,

making every breath feel like glass being rubbed.

My playlist won't stream.

My group chat won't load.

The post I meant to share won't arrive.

The world goes offline but my body stays online.

Tanya's fingers tap the table:

three quick, one long - like a code she learned from scratched vinyl.

I flip a switch that isn't Wi-Fi.

I switch from waiting to working.

I pull a USB out my pocket, grimy with pocket dust,

and the music finally stops begging.

Still - static keeps whispering.

It crawls through the gaps like it's trying to complete a sentence.

It says: *you thought you were powerless.*

It says: *you were just connected.*

The sun doesn't care about my setup.

It doesn't care if I'm ready.

It turns the air into a furnace and the silence into a drum.

Static takes my fear, boils it down,

and leaves a shape I can hold.

A crack that spreads into a path.

I lick my lips - dry, salty, sunburn.

I taste metal again.

And the hiss comes back warmer,

like it's laughing at my old habits.

How loud can the universe be

when your connection goes quiet?

Hiss That Answers

WiFi cut.

But the speaker still breathes.

A thin scream of static climbs up the line,

then folds into something almost like language.

I can't translate it clean,

but I can feel it aiming at my nervous system.

Tanya turns the dial by ear, not by bars.

No signal meters, just muscle memory.

She's nineteen, community college,

and she's learned the hard way:

sometimes the only stable thing is your rhythm.

The sun hits my forehead again - same spot, same burn.

It feels like a stamp.

Like the day is marking me for whatever comes next.

The hiss whispers back:

not sweet, not soft - a backhanded truth with teeth.

It says my excuses sound the same as my worries.

It says I keep reaching for a connection

while the real connection is the work.

I try to refresh my phone.

It spins.

The loading circle becomes a tiny torture wheel.

Static fills the room like smoke you can't see.

It curls around the cables.

It finds the seams in the setup

and worries them until they open.

I hear it in the pauses between beats - a ghost DJ scratching the turntable with static nails.

"Say it again," I mutter, stubborn.

The hiss doesn't repeat.

It mutates - higher, lower, sharper - like it's testing my attention.

The sun keeps cooking my skin.

My patience evaporates.

But my hands don't leave.

I count measures with my knuckles.

I slam the cue button like a door.

I let the noise be part of the mix,

because fighting it just makes it louder.

Static whispers back anyway:

you don't need permission to make sound.

you don't need a signal to be real.

The router stays dead.

The sun stays hot.

The room stays full.

And the crack in the connection becomes a crack in the mask - not the golden one,
not yet - just the first split where honesty leaks out.

What if the cut isn't the loss - what if it's the inventory starting?

First-Crack Inventory

Router dead.

Sun loud.

Static talking like it got a job.

I start the First-Crack Inventory without a checklist.

Just listening - to the hiss, to the heat, to the way my anger changes tempo.

Item one: the blue light that won't glow.

I watch it refuse me.

I watch it hold its silence like a grudge.

Item two: the sun on my face, steady and cruel.

It makes my eyes water.

It turns my breath into steam.

Item three: the whisper in the static.

It doesn't soothe me.

It confronts me.

I press play on the wrong thing - then catch myself.

The mistake stings clean.

Like getting slapped awake.

The hiss laughs in the background,

a laugh made of frequencies.

It says: *you keep trying to fix the wrong problem.*

It says: *you want the internet to be your lifeline.*

Tanya's knuckles tap the desk again - a rhythm for the moment when the world breaks.

Three quick, one long, repeat.

Like a ritual that fits in one hand.

I try another device.

No.

Another.

No.

Still the music can move.

Not through Wi-Fi - through me.

I pull the cable tight.

I re-seat the plug like I'm sealing a wound.

I check the settings once - fast - then stop overthinking like it's a hobby.

The static shifts, almost approving.

It whispers back softer for half a second,

then hardens again - like it wants me to earn the calm.

The sun burns the same spot on my cheek.

Heat makes my thoughts sharper, meaner.

My frustration turns into fuel.

The First Crack Inventory isn't about fixing everything.

It's about naming what broke first - so I can stop pretending the crack isn't there.

When the Wi-Fi dies, I don't die with it.

When the sun hits, I don't look away.

When the static whispers back, I don't mute it.

I just track the truth as it comes in.

What else have I been calling "signal"

when it was really just avoidance?

Golden Noise Start

Static comes in like a confession I didn't ask for.

Wi-Fi stays gone, no mercy, no comeback.

The sun presses my face like it's trying to read my skin.

I stand my ground in the heat.

My phone can't reach the cloud.

So I reach for the beat with both hands.

Tanya - nineteen - community college DJ - her focus gets mean when the bars disappear.

She stops begging the screen

and starts driving the sound.

The hiss whispers back, steady now,

like a mentor with no patience.

Like a warning label with a rhythm.

It says: *you built your confidence on a connection.*

It says: *now test it without the leash.*

It says: *if you can't make it when it cuts out, you were never making it.*

I swallow that.

My throat is dry from sun and rage.

I flip a switch.

I cue a track from storage.

The speakers thump - real, physical - and the static doesn't vanish.

It rides the edges like grime on gold.

The sun hits again.

I close one eye and keep the other open.

I don't let the brightness bully me into panic.

The hiss whispers back, quieter, almost intimate:

you're still listening.

you're still counting time.

you didn't lose the ear.

My heart tries to sprint ahead of the moment.

I drag it back with the kick drum.

I make the crack useful.

WiFi cut.

Sunburn.

Static talking like it's reading my mind out loud.

And I realize the first crack ain't the router.

It's the lie that silence means failure.

It's the lie that I need a signal to be a voice.

So I name it - not with a prayer,

not with a refresh button - with sound that survives the cut.

The golden mask can wait.

First, I learn the hiss.

First, I answer the backtalk.

Static whispering, sun striking - I keep the tempo anyway.

CHAPTER 2

Write Through the Glitch



Buffer Forever

“K eep it spinning,” the screen says with a grin made of loading dots.

My thumb hits refresh like it owes me rent.

Wheel turns, nothing moves, just the same circle chewing time.

The warehouse Wi-Fi coughs - two bars, then a funeral.

I’m on the night shift, gloves on, jaw clenched.

The scanner blinks red, then ghosts my barcode.

My shadow’s on strike behind the pallets.

It won’t follow my feet on the concrete.

It lags like a late check, like a debt with teeth.

I type my work order, it stutters mid-sentence.

“Error,” it spits - like the Machine hates my breath.

I try to debug my brain with brute force caffeine.

I uncap my marker, write “FIX” on a clipboard.

The ink bleeds slightly, like the system’s laughing.

I restart the router - power off, power on - same curse.
"Say it again," my mouth whispers to the app.
My mind won't debug, it just loops the failure.
Every thought becomes a buffering bar, stuck at 27%.
My shadow protests in the corner of my eye.
It's darker than it should be, thicker than grief.
Like it filed a union complaint against my optimism.
I punch the time clock anyway - hard enough to feel real.
The display flickers, then smears my hours into static.
I keep moving, because stopping feeds the glitch.
"Not today," I tell the loading wheel, not loud - just mean.
The dots keep dancing like they're getting paid.
So I write lines that cut through the spin.

Glitch Draft Sonnet

The loading wheel won't die on my command,
It turns like tires on slick-ass warehouse floors;
My shadow's on strike, it won't hold my hand,
It drags behind me like unpaid wars.

I type the same request, it breaks again,

The Machine coughs up error codes like spit;

My mind won't debug - can't scrub out the stain,

Just replays the stall till my vision's lit.

I hit refresh like hitting up a plug,

A dead end circuit that won't give me signal;

I read my thoughts like receipts I can't scrub,

Numbers bleeding through the paper's gospel.

So I write lines till the bars get out my way,

And force the silence to load into day.

Shadow Strike Haikus

My display buffers - loading dots eat my minutes,

shadow breaks rank.

Router coughs static,

scanner won't read the label,

my mind won't debug.

I reset again - power light stays stubborn red,

shadow still strikes.

Clipboard ink shakes,

“FIX” looks like a threat, not hope,

warehouse hums back.

I swear at the wheel - it keeps spinning, same damn loop,

so I write through it.

Debugging Rhyme

Loading dots keep looping, loading dots keep looping,

My shift clock flickers, my shift clock flickers too,

Shadow on strike won't slide where feet are moving,

My mind won't debug, it won't debug me through.

I reboot the router, I reboot the router,

Red light stays hungry, red light stays rude,

Pallets stack like doubts I can't outrun or barter,

Shadow on strike won't slide where feet are moving.

I type the same order, I type the same order,

App spits “error” like it's chewing my cue,

I beg the screen - no mercy, no reward, no border,

My mind won't debug, it won't debug me through.

Loading dots keep looping, loading dots keep looping,
I scratch "FIX" in marker, I scratch it in blue,
Through the static, I spit bars like a promise I'm proving,
Shadow on strike won't slide where feet are moving,
My mind won't debug, it won't debug me through.

Glitch-to-Line Drill

The warehouse WiFi stalls right when I need it most - right when the work order's due, right when the line's moving.

My scanner screen shows 0, then 0 again.

I can hear the fans in the ceiling like they're mocking my breath.

I slap the side of the device - once, not twice - like violence will download a fix.

It doesn't.

It just buffers forever, polite as a liar.

My shadow - behind the pallets - won't match my stance.

It splits at the edges, like it's buffering too.

I look down and it's late to everything I do.

Late to my steps, late to my patience, late to my rage.

I try to debug with logic the way folks say to - but my brain keeps compiling the same failure.

Every solution turns into another loading wheel.

Every “try again” becomes a longer wait.

So I switch tools.

Not the router.

Not the reset button.

I grab a roll of tape and a marker from my pocket,

walk to the concrete column by Bay 3,

and write a line thick enough to cut the air.

“BUFFER FOREVER” in block letters, ugly and loud.

Then I write the next line under it - a second blade, a second breath.

I stack words like pallets I can finally lift.

The app still hangs.

The screen still spins.

But my chest stops sinking.

My shadow’s strike gets smaller - like it can’t hold out against ink.

Like it’s forced to clock in when I start rhyming back.

I don’t solve the glitch.

I route around it.

I keep writing while the dots keep dancing,
and the longer it takes, the sharper the line gets.

At 27% I start another verse.

At 28% I don't flinch.

At 29% my mind finally feels less trapped - not fixed, but fed.

Buffer forever, sure - but I'm turning that loop into a fuse,
and when the fuse burns, the silence learns my name.

CHAPTER 3



Flip Fate Backward

Flipback Schedule

My phone says 6:13, but the clock on the bus says 6:03 - ten minutes of beef with time.

Marisol punches the driver badge, hears the scanner stutter, and the reversed horoscope slides under her tongue like a bad pill:

“DO NOT MOVE FORWARD; MOVE BACKWARD.”

She laughs once, quick - then the route reorders itself in her head, stop numbers turning into wrong doors, each one asking for a signature she don't remember signing.

The stars keep talking in a language she can't read clean, only feel: unreadable secrets, thumbled like receipts, proof that fate is a clerk who hates her handwriting.

When the turn signal clicks, it's late by a heartbeat; when she brakes, it's early - like the road is playing tug-of-war with her lungs.

Reversed Omen

I read it backward, like a receipt with the ink bleeding out.

I read it backward, and the sentence turns to a dare I can't ignore.

I read it backward, and the “avoid” sounds like “come closer.”

I read it backward, and the “wait” lands like a shove.

I read it backward, and the “don’t call” becomes a dial tone in my bones.

I read it backward, and the “be careful” turns into a cracked bell that won’t stop ringing.

I read it backward, and the planet names look like nicknames for trouble.

I read it backward, and the moon phase flips like a switch in a dark room.

I read it backward, and my timing gets indicted - late to the moment, early to the damage.

I read it backward, and I swear the stars are laughing through static.

I read it backward, and my mouth tastes like copper and misalignment.

I read it backward, and every “warning” drives straight through the windshield.

Mis-timed Layout

6:03 on the dash - 6:13 on my phone - 10 minutes

stacked like pennies

STOP 12

slides under STOP 11

slides under STOP 10

the route keeps rewinding

the fare box keeps blinking

like it's counting down

to the wrong door

I brake

then I brake again

then the brake lights

argue with the air

Bus Stop Rewind

The reversed horoscope said don't go forward - so I go forward

and my body files a complaint.

At 6:07 the next stop is already gone.

At 6:07 I'm still catching up

to a moment that stole its own key.

A passenger asks, "You late?"

I want to say, "I'm on time for the wrong universe,"

but my mouth don't know that dialect.

The stars keep their secrets unreadable - not blank, not silent,

just written in glare.

I watch the windshield for clues:

the crosswalk stripes twitch like they're buffering.

The engine hums a low threat,

like a drumline practicing without a crowd.

My signal clicks - one beat behind,

one beat ahead,

fate doing math with no teacher.

Every red light feels personal.

Every green feels like a trap with lipstick on it.

When I flip the horoscope back to front,

the words don't change - my timing does.

My hands still know the wheel,

but my life keeps missing the beat

by half a breath.

Unreadable Secrets

My watch runs backwards in my head,

and the bus keeps arriving late to my own future.

The stars won't translate - only tighten, only test, only bruise,

like "don't" is a door that opens into more "don't."

Karma doesn't knock; it counts,

and the number it lands on is never mine.

I brake early for a crash that hasn't happened,

then swerve late for a lesson that already did.

So I flip fate backward and drive through the wrong clock,

turning mis-timing into momentum, turning momentum into a mask that shines.

CHAPTER 4



Turn Trauma Into Rhythm

Roulette Tongue

The lighter broke - again - right when the dealer said "spin."

Two blunts on my lap, no flame, just trauma in the groove.

Karma slid the cards like teeth: "You pay in sound."

Karma Spins

Two blunts wait - no lighter sparks, just

trauma tapping time

Karma shoves chips - each hit clicks like a lock

on the old bruise

I flick ash with spite - smoke makes a crooked halo

over my receipts

Table turns my ribs - the numbers land on "again"

I swallow the ring

I laugh, then flinch - Karma smiles through the pain

and calls it rhythm

No Flame Games

Karma deals roulette with a dead lighter in my pocket.

Two blunts still breathe, but the burn comes from shock.

The ball don't care where I got hurt - it lands like a punchline, it lands like the truth.

"Spin," say the dealer, "pay," say my jaw.

I pay in syllables, I pay in raw.

My hands shake - then tighten - like a snare wire.

I don't need fire, I need a tempo to survive.

Blackout heat in my mouth, still I hold the hit.

Karma counts my cracks like coins I can't quit.

Ash on my sleeve, I'm still clocking the beat.

Every flinch gets a bar, every bar gets teeth.

Two blunts. No lighter.

Same lesson: control the roll, control the riot.

Karma's smile gets sharper every time I try to quit.

So I rap the wound open and let the sound commit.

Burnless Rounds

Karma's table hums - coin clinks, my ribs answer

in metronome

I cup the blunt close - heat from anger, no flame

just pressure rising

My throat writes scratch - each inhale turns to lines

I didn't choose

Karma flips the card - I see my old face there

then swap it out

The roulette wheel spins - "again" hits my tongue hard

like a final word

Trauma-Tap Meter

No flame, so I tap trauma into time.

Tap - tap - Karma pays attention, every rhyme.

Dealer got a calm voice, sharp eyes, no pity.

I shuffle my memories like cards that won't sit pretty.

Two blunts, no lighter, I still light up the bar.

I spark with spite, I spark with scar.

My wrist keeps the count when my chest wants to fold.

I set the beat like a lock on a door I don't own.

Karma says "double." I double down on the syllable.

If you want my pain, at least let it be audible.

I choke on the old fear, then I choke it into flow.

My anger learns choreography, my voice becomes a go.

The table wants me broke - wants me stuck, wants me small.

So I turn that wanting into a drum I can't stall.

I spit the truth like ash that won't quit.

Karma hears it, stamps it, then lets the smoke commit.

Two Blunts

Karma slides the chips like she already knows my sentence.

The lighter's gone - cracked, dead, vanished - like a promise I was supposed to believe.

Two blunts lay there heavy, blunt ends pointing at my bad decisions.

I press my thumb into the wrap, feel the seam of every bruise.

"Spin," she says, calm as a cut.

The roulette wheel laughs in numbers I can't unlearn.

I tap my knuckles on the table - Trauma-Tap Meter, steady and mean.

Tick for the night it happened.

Tick for the day I tried to act normal.

Tick until my panic turns into percussion.

No flame, so the fire is internal.

Not cute, not healing - just survival with a bassline.

I hear my own breath getting louder than my shame.

I hear the ash fall like receipts.

I hear Karma's voice in the clack of the wheel: pay attention, pay attention.

The ball drops - boom - on "again."

I don't beg. I don't plead. I don't bargain with ghosts.

I rap the bruise into barbed rhythm, make the hurt stand up straight.

I take the dealer's deal and flip it into a hook.

Two blunts, no lighter - still I spark in the throat.

Karma can keep spinning, I keep tapping, I keep holding the sound.

CHAPTER 5



Tattoo Regret on Walls

Ink on Plaster

Why does regret stick harder than fresh stencil paste?

I'm watching my wall breathe through dried drips,

a subway-map of mistakes, laid out in beige and bruised gold.

Nia, 24, tattoo apprentice - so the needle never stops shaking,

so the hand keeps reaching for the next line like it's mercy.

But the wall don't care.

It holds everything.

I press the cap back on the bottle too fast,

and the black blooms into a bruise-shaped halo.

"Don't waste ink," my boss says - then counts my seconds like rent.

I count the seconds too.

I count the times I said "I'm fine" with my mouth full of ash.

I wrote it once on paper, then crossed it out,

like erasing could un-happen the night I rushed the stencil.

The Subconscious Stain Method - yeah, I named it like a spell - so I blot the smear,
then I let it stain on purpose.

I sign in blood on printer paper,

cheap sheets soaked at the edges,

ink dragging like it's angry at my wrist.

I practice on oranges, then on skin,

then I look at my own letters on plaster:

they don't sit still.

One regret says: you didn't ask for consent,

another says: you didn't listen when your gut warned you.

They overlap like tattoos under bad lighting,

like flash on wet concrete.

I keep the ink moving - no pause, no hesitation - because if I stop, the regret settles
in,

and it settles like a landlord.

"Cover it," somebody jokes.

I don't cover.

I rework the line.

I cut deeper where the truth got thin.

I set a timer for 7 minutes,

wipe with alcohol until my fingertips sting,

then go back - same wall, new pressure.

The plaster keeps my ghost prints.

The ink keeps my name.

I hear the needle tap the table - tick, tick - like a clock that only counts what you didn't fix.

Aftertaste Vows

I wrote "sorry" on the wall with a needle, then it bled to the plaster of the room,
BLOOD

I tried to scrub it clean with alcohol swabs - foam turned to proof, **BLOOD**

I signed my hate in red on paper and folded it tight in my pocket, **BLOOD**

I watched the corner curl like skin healing wrong, then called it "practice," **BLOOD**

I inked over my own mistakes like tape over a wound that won't close, **BLOOD**

I hear my doubt in every drip, a metronome for what I can't un-know, **BLOOD**

I left the stain where it landed, because hiding makes it louder, **BLOOD**

I'm still the apprentice with the restless hand, the one who learns too late, **BLOOD**

My name in the margin shakes when the lights hit hard - Nia, **BLOOD**

Wet Cement Regrets

The wall takes black like it's thirsty,

like the plaster's been waiting for confession.

I drag the tattoo pen across masking tape,

and the line looks clean for half a second - then the ink finds the crack in my calm.

"Keep it moving," I mutter,

and the needle answers with that tiny, violent hum.

I'm not chasing perfection.

I'm chasing motion that won't freeze.

I do three passes on the same section:

first to lay it down,

second to deepen the truth,

third to stop pretending it's not there.

My phone's on airplane mode,

but the regret still sends notifications.

I remember how I rushed the stencil last month,

how I told myself "it'll be fine" - then watched the stencil drift like a lie slipping off skin.

On the counter: a roll of printer paper,

a cup of ink,

a stack of swabs,

and my notes written in shaky block letters.

I sign in blood again,

not because I'm dramatic - because the stain proves I was present.

Paper gets it wrong easier than walls do.

Paper forgives.

Walls don't.

The black soaks in, then darkens,

like it's reading my thoughts and replying.

When I wipe, it smears into new shapes,

and suddenly the mistake looks like a map.

I follow that map with the needle,

turn the regret into a groove,

then groove it deeper until it stops begging.

My wrist hurts.

My confidence hurts.

The wall still stands there, undefeated.

I want the regret to stop living rent-free in my skull,

so I make it pay in ink.

I keep the ink moving - not to escape,

to anchor.

Because every time the line trembles,

I feel the moment I chose wrong,

and I choose again while the needle's hot.

The plaster listens.

The plaster keeps score.

So I don't ask the wall to forget.

I ask it to remember my correction.

Subconscious Stain

The stain method is simple and brutal: blot, don't erase. I lay down regret like a stencil, then I give it something to grip - alcohol on a swab, printer paper soaked at the edges, a hard wipe that turns "mistake" into texture. When the ink runs, I don't panic; I steer it. I hold the pen steady for exactly long enough to feel the tremor start, then I move before it can settle into a permanent lie. The wall shows me what my mouth tried to hide - pressure points of choices, thick lines where I rushed, thin spots where I froze. If I sign in blood on paper, the paper can't pretend. If the wall stains it back, my subconscious can't pretend either. It's not art class. It's receipts.

Momentum Wound

I scrape the excess ink off the cap

and it sticks like attitude.

The wall's got my previous attempts - ghost outlines, half-finished letters,

a whole argument frozen in matte black.

Nia, 24, tattoo apprentice - hands still learning,

but the mind already knows how it hurt.

I reload the needle like a threat.

I don't blink.

The second pass is where the regret tries to win,

where it tells me to stop,

where it says "you can't fix this."

I laugh once, short and mean,

because I've seen how regret behaves - it settles when you hesitate.

So I move.

I mark a new line adjacent to the old one,

not to erase, to redirect.

I let the old stain bleed through the fresh ink

like the past is still in the room,

but now it's got boundaries.

I set a timer again - 5 minutes this time - and I work until my forearm feels like a bruise with rhythm.

My swab comes back darker than it should,

and I take that as proof:

the stain is still active,

my subconscious still transferring ink from thought to wall.

I press harder where the guilt is thick,

then ease up where the shame thins out.

I watch the letters form,

not pretty - true.

When somebody says "just cover it,"

I hear the real question hiding under the joke:

Are you scared to let people see the mistake?

I'm scared.

I'm also stubborn.

So I keep the ink moving

until the regret becomes a pattern I can survive.

Until the wall stops feeling like a threat

and starts feeling like a ledger.

Until my next line lands

with the weight of correction,

not just the weight of damage.

And if the stain stays - fine - I'll turn the stain into momentum,

because silence is how regret gets comfortable,

and I'm done letting it stretch out on my skin.

CHAPTER 6

Solve the Rubik With Force

“Turn it or it turns you”

Rubik’s Cube in my left hand, knuckles white from the click.

The right one hunts the hammer like it’s already understood.

I set the cube on the floor - hard tile, loud truth.

Six faces staring back like they all got receipts.

“Click,” I say, and it listens.

Each snap a little permission slip for my brain to move.

I don’t need luck, I need snapped-together angles.

I need the corners to stop acting like they’re scared.

Hammer-Click Reframe - tap, then twist, then tap again.

Not prayer, not therapy, just mechanics with a mouth.

Piece one won’t sit? I force the fit.

Piece two slips? I hit pause on the ego.

The cube complains in plastic creaks and tiny shocks.

My thoughts do the same when they’re out of alignment.

I count rotations like lug nuts: quarter-turn, check, tighten.

I don't rush the pattern; I bully the chaos into order.

"Stop fighting me," I tell the cube.

Then I tell myself the same thing, lower and meaner.

A red square lands where it belongs.

My chest does too, like it's been waiting for that exact click.

I grip the hammer again.

Not to break - just to make the stubborn pieces agree.

Hammer-Click Reframe

The cube's on the mat like a suspect who won't talk.

Blue on top, green on the side, white hiding in the seams.

I try the usual - fingers, pressure, patience.

The pieces laugh at me in tiny plastic syllables.

So I switch the rhythm.

Tap the hammer once - metal on tile, sharp and final.

Click.

Twist.

Click.

My mind does that same stutter-step.

A thought tries to bolt, then gets cuffed by the pattern.

I see it now: snapped-together pieces, not "random."

Even when it feels like a curse, it's still a system.

The hammer's not a temper tantrum.

It's a clock hand I swing to keep time from stealing me.

I rack the cube back to the mess.

Same scramble every time, like an opponent who rematches.

Then I go again.

Quarter-turns, diagonal grabs, that one stubborn edge that always lies.

"Come on," I whisper, not nice.

The cube answers with a hard little click-pop.

I lay the cross down - four whites - clean as a fresh gasket.

I slam the last layer into place like it owes me money.

The final face shows up.

No miracles, just correct pressure and the right sequence.

My brain tries to follow the cube's rules.

It stops spinning like a broke fan.

I hit the hammer to the tile one more time.

The sound says: solved is a verb, not a wish.

Misaligned Tongue

The cube sits open like a mouth with missing teeth.

Pieces half-turned, colors stacked wrong, attitude loud.

I talk to it like it's the only thing that won't lie.

"Fix yourself," I say, "or I'm fixing you."

Hammer-Click Reframe again - tap first, then move.

Metal bite, then wrist snap, then the next snap.

Click - black shifts.

Click - orange finds its lane.

Click - white slides home like a key in a lock.

My tongue keeps trying to spit excuses.

I feel it get stuck on the wrong color.

I'm not gentle with myself when I'm choking.

I'm mechanical: tighten, align, stop the leak of meaning.

The cube gives me feedback fast.

A wrong move shows up instantly, no soft landing.

My head hates that.

My head wants delay, wants fog, wants “maybe later.”

But the cube doesn’t do later.

It demands the next correct click.

So I do what I do with bolts.

I don’t romance the stripped one - I replace the angle.

One piece won’t go? I reset the layer.

I pull it back to the last stable set.

I hammer the tile again - not hard, just decisive.

A reminder: action first, analysis after.

The cube locks.

My breath follows it, shorter, steadier.

Then the last edge snaps in like a promise kept.

And my inner noise goes quiet for a minute - earned, not given.

I feel the solution in my hands.

Not peace - control.

Mental Slammer

A Rubik’s Cube is a cage with rules.

I build it with the hammer’s rhythm and the click’s authority.

My thoughts used to run wild - scramble, scramble, scramble.

Now I herd them by layers, by pressure, by timing.

I start with the top cross like a blueprint.

Four squares, same size, same intent.

Click - click - click - click.

The sound is a drill sergeant for my nervous system.

Then I chase the corners into place.

They resist like stubborn screws in rust.

Hammer-Click Reframe: tap, twist, tap, settle.

I don't negotiate with the misfit.

If a corner turns the wrong way, I backtrack.

I don't call it failure; I call it recalibration.

The cube teaches consequences in real time.

No "in theory," no "someday" - just wrong moves that show up.

My mental slammer forms out of snapped-together pieces.

Each locked section becomes a bar I can lean on.

When my anger tries to freestyle, I set the next algorithm.

Front face, side face, return the cube - clean and cold.

I hear my own voice inside the plastic clicks:

"Hold the line. Finish the layer. Don't fold."

The hammer rests near my palm, ready like a tool.

Not violence - structure.

When the cube solves, my mind doesn't float.

It locks in place like a toolbox that finally closes.

I grip the last piece into alignment.

Click.

And the slammer door shuts on the chaos - tight enough to keep.

The Last Layer Noise

The last layer refuses to cooperate at first.

I stare at yellow like it's a liar with perfect posture.

I try the rotations I memorized.

The cube answers with more wrong.

So I use the hammer as a metronome.

Tap - then I commit to the next twist, no hesitation.

Click.

Twist.

Click.

The pattern reveals itself like fingerprints under light.

Edges line up, corners rotate, the cube starts talking back.

Hammer-Click Reframe keeps my hands from freezing.

It keeps my brain from spiraling into "what if I mess up."

I mess up anyway - then I fix it fast.

Reset a layer, correct the angle, re-enter the grid.

The cube's seams show where I'm sloppy.

I can't blame the universe when the plastic says, "No."

One wrong turn and the whole face looks crooked.

One right turn and suddenly it's clean.

My chest tightens with the same fear my mouth used to carry.

I feel it, then I press through it like a stubborn bearing.

Click - green sits.

Click - red locks.

Click - yellow finally owns the top.

The cube's solved, but the noise stays in my ears.

Not regret - momentum.

I lift it, and the colors stay set.

No sliding, no drifting, no "almost."

Hammer on tile, one last crisp sound.

Not to break the cube - just to seal the lesson.

My mental slammer holds.

Snapped-together pieces, locked by force and timing.

Now the next problem in my head knows the rules:

turn with purpose, click with discipline, and don't let the chaos win.



Record the Buffering Future

Buffer Wheel

The loading ring spins like a cheap halo on my screen,
 June, 22, streaming editor - thumb hovering over "replay,"
 the timeline still warm where I scrubbed it raw,
 green bar stuck at 13% like it's laughing at my rent.
 "Play," I whisper at the player,
 it answers with a wheel that never finishes chewing.
 I hit rewind - the past slaps back into place with a sticky click,
 clip 00:00:07 returns,
 and the sound comes back wrong, like a throat trying to remember.
 Buffer wheel, buffer wheel, count your circles,
 I can feel the seconds turning into tax forms.
 My cursor drags through the same frame,
 frame after frame - a manhole cover of silence over the mix,
 no voice, just the hiss where the drop should land.

Then - restart.

The old take blooms again,

but it's a ghost wearing yesterday's files,

the waveform repeating like it got a contract.

I mute it to see if the room changes,

my ears still hear the loop.

My phone vibrates: "Try again."

Try again like that's a prayer I can edit into faith.

The silence between replays gets loud,

a black screen with teeth,

a pause that holds my throat shut

while the future circles, circling, circling.

I drag the export like it owes me money,

progress bar stares, then blinks,

and I swear the wheel is writing my name in lag

so the next version can disappoint me faster.

Lagged Retribution

A loading wheel keeps turning without end,

my cursor drags through frames I can't trust;
the past hits rewind, hard on the same bend,
like broken glass that still cuts when you must.
I hear the silence clench inside the mix,
a pause that chews the beat to dust and grit;
the waveform loops - stubborn, slick, and slicker tricks,
then dies mid-note like it got hit with quit.
I beg the player, "Finish what you started,"
it offers only circles, only delay;
future hangs like a file never uploaded,
while yesterday replays and steals the day.
So when it loads, it loads me back - reveal:
the gap between replays is where I feel.

Thirteen Percent

Thirteen percent - stuck.

Rewind slams the same second

till silence snaps back.

Green wheel keeps spinning.

Past returns with wrong audio,

like tape with no soul.

I mute the room.

Hiss grows teeth in the gap - future won't land.

Export bar blinks.

Past keeps walking in circles,

future still buffering.

Infinite Stutter

The loading wheel keeps dancing, never done,

the past hits rewind, the past hits rewind;

my timeline's stuck on the same wrong one,

and silence sells me back my time.

I scrub the cut, it slips - another spin,

the past hits rewind, the past hits rewind;

the countdown dies before it can begin,

and silence sells me back my time.

I press “play” hard, knuckles on the glass,

the past hits rewind, the past hits rewind;

the waveform lies in a glitchy class,

and silence sells me back my time.

I delete the file, it returns again,

the past hits rewind, the past hits rewind;

the future stalls like a door on a chain,

and silence sells me back my time.

I watch 13% like it’s court-appointed,

the past hits rewind, the past hits rewind;

then the screen goes blank and I’m still routed - and silence sells me back my time.

Replay-Loop Notebook

June, 22, streaming editor, I can’t sleep with the wheel still breathing,

my hand hovering over “restart” like it’s a loaded trigger.

The past keeps hitting rewind - not a memory, a mechanism - clip count, timestamp,
the same jagged seven seconds

snapping back into the cut like a trapdoor.

I open the Replay-Loop Notebook

and write what the screen won't say:

"Future: buffering forever."

"Past: returning with fingerprints."

Then I cross it out and write it again, harder.

The silence between replays is a room with no lights,

but it still charges my phone.

I hear my own breathing echo through it - a metronome made of nowhere.

I test the audio one more time,

set the levels with a cheap dial that shakes,

monitor says clean,

the ear says counterfeit.

A loading wheel spins at 13% like a bully with patience,

like the universe got an editor's job and hates me personally.

Every time I think it'll drop the next frame,

it gives me the same freeze - a still image of a moment that refuses to become real.

"Just export," I say,

the file doesn't care.

The wheel doesn't care.

The gap between replays does the most damage.

So I try a different take - same beat, new sound, fresh breath - and the past hits
rewind anyway,

stealing the new from the mouth of the now.

I slam the notebook shut,

but the loops keep living in the paper.

The page stays warm where my anger sits,

and the future keeps circling, circling, circling - until even silence starts to stutter,

until I understand the only way out is to break the loop before it breaks me,

and I'm still learning how to do that with my hands steady on the wheel.



Name the Scream No One Hears

Melted Face Message

The monitor kept saying “normal” while my knuckles shook. A call came in - no hero music, just fluorescent buzz and the kind of silence that has teeth. I held pressure on a wound that wouldn’t behave, watched the heat rise like bad news, and someone screamed somewhere behind the walls of the system - too late, too far, never named. The face went shiny, not cinematic, just melted in a way that made my stomach flip its own switch. I tried to file it, tried to call it by its proper name, but the words kept slipping like wet gloves.

When I asked, “What happened?” the room answered with paperwork and static. The scream stayed unanswered, the heart stayed frigid - like it learned survival from the cold side of the stretcher, like it learned to live with a missing sound.

Unanswered-Scream Map

I map the scream that never got a timestamp.

I map the scream that got swallowed by “we’ll call you.”

I map the scream that hits first, then the body follows.

I map the scream that cracks the ceiling tiles in my head.

I map the scream that no one files because it has no receipt.

I map the scream that sounds like a warning in a language nobody learned.

I map the scream that keeps breathing after the room goes quiet.

I map the scream that melts your face but leaves your eyes ice-cold.

I map the scream that makes you check the pulse twice just to be sure.

I map the scream that gets answered with a shrug and a clipboard.

I map the scream that turns “help” into a delay timer.

I map the scream that walks out of the dispatch notes and doesn’t come back.

I map the scream that stays in the throat like a locked door.

I map the scream that my hands remember even when my head tries not to.

I map the scream that says, “Name me,” but the world won’t spell it right.

I map the scream until the heart learns frigid math: still here, still not fixed.

Ice-Chemistry

NAME THE SCREAM

no form fields

no checkbox prayers

MELTED FACE

heat on the surface

cold in the core

HEART STAYS FRIGID

like a saved rhythm

skipping the note

I CHECK THE PULSE

1-2 - 3 - again

the same answer, different fear

DISPATCH STATIC

numbers talk

screams don't

UNANSWERED

not unanswered

just un-named

just un-heard

WRITE IT SOMEWHERE

12-lead won't translate it

cuff won't compress it

tape won't hold it

breath will

Pulse Aftermath

I heard the scream through the radio's bad connection.

Not loud - wrong. Like it arrived already tired.

My hands did what they're trained to do - gloved pressure, steady voice, count it out.

But the scream didn't care about my procedure.

It kept climbing the back of my skull.

The face got hot in a way that didn't look like heat.

Skin turned into a warning label.

"Keep her comfortable," someone said,

like comfort is a setting you can switch on.

I watched the monitor hold steady,

as if the machine could lie better than people.

I tried to name what I was seeing - my mouth formed words, but they fell flat.

Because the scream stayed unanswered,

and my heart stayed frigid anyway.

Not numb like peace.

Numb like the body clocking overtime.

When the room finally quieted,

the scream kept moving in silence.

I felt it in the space between breaths,

a locked door with no handle.

I don't know if grief is loud.

I know it can be cold.

I know it can wait.

And I know the next call will come - with clean gloves and dirty echoes.

Frigid Stillness

The scream didn't get a name, so it stayed real.

My heart stayed frigid, so I stayed functional.

The face melted like a promise breaking slow.

My pulse kept counting while the sound kept missing.

They asked for details like details could heal.

I had only heat on skin and ice in meaning.

Paperwork got filed; the scream got buried.

I walked with cold courage in my chest, still learning.

If you can't hear it, you can't answer it.

So I map the unanswered - until the world listens.

CHAPTER 9



Chase Wi-Fi Ghosts

Router Static Psalms

Why does my sentence crack when the bars turn gray?

The debug light blinks like it's judging me,

then my throat becomes a buffering wheel.

Ghosted Signal

Static on the line - my words get chewed mid-send,

router hisses "no."

I dial up "please load,"

the screen shows a blank prayer,

time stamps the silence.

Wi-Fi ghost in bars,

spelling my name wrong in dust,

I choke on every vowel.

I slap the cable tight,
it still drifts like bad memory,
signal lies again.

The modem warms up,
then cools - like it took my confession,
leaves me on mute.

Misheard Messages

Your "be right there"
turns into "be gone" in my ears.

The ghost in the router
keeps typing with my mouth.

I hit refresh like CPR
on a dead group chat.

The SSID keeps changing
like a liar with a new wig.

I reset the modem - static still wears my face.

The phone says "connected"

but my thoughts stay disconnected.

I sing my password under breath,

the house swallows it whole.

When the signal returns,

it brings receipts I didn't send.

Static-Sentence

My mouth gets stung - every syllable falls through

the gap in the bars.

Priya presses keys,

the helpdesk ticket won't load,

her cursor shakes back.

A whisper in packet - "try again" sounds like a threat,

then laughs in frames.

I cup my ears to it,

the router spits out a sermon

made of broken pings.

The blame light blinks - it don't point at the cable,

it points at her tongue.

Ghost Cache

She clears the ghost cache with a restart

and the silence comes back faster.

"Reset to factory?" - no, she won't beg

for permission from a box that lies.

Tool on her desk: paperclip,

then Q-tip, then patience - still no.

The modem's logs read like threats

in timestamps that won't explain shit.

Priya says, "Ethernet, don't play,"

and the line still stutters like teeth.

She checks the channel - 1, 6, 11 - the neighbor's router steals the air.

Her headphones catch whispers in the static,

soft as receipts, sharp as cuffs.

When she finally hears herself again,

the words arrive warped, like they aged in a firewall.

Priya's Last Clear Ping

The ticket keeps spinning - circle on circle, no answer, no mercy.

"Can you hear me?" she types,

but the cursor blinks like it's coughing.

Static climbs the glass screen.

Her inbox turns into a throat full of sand.

"Use Ethernet," the chat says,

like a spell you can cast without hands.

She plugs the cable in - click, click, light turns green.

Green means nothing

when the ghost keeps writing over the signal.

Her voice cracks on the next sentence.

Not crying - just glitching, like audio on a bad upload.

"Priya," the supervisor says in her head,

the word lands heavy like a log file.

She opens the logs - SNR numbers, error codes, little dead insects.

The router's UI smiles

while the packets walk out early.

She tries the Static-Sentence Technique:

pause, split it clean, send smaller pieces.

"Printer... offline."

"Switch... blinking."

"Port... flapping."

Each fragment still comes back wrong - like the static learned her grammar.

Then the whisper rides the line again:

not words, just distortion wearing a voice.

She hears, "You're late,"

when she never said time.

She hears, "You failed,"

when all she did was troubleshoot.

Her fingers hover over reboot.

She's tired of resetting the same wound.

So she does it different - power cycle, wait thirty seconds, then rejoin.

Thirty seconds is a whole lifetime

when you're fighting something that can't be caught.

The connection pops - bars rise like a lie that wants applause.

She sends the fix summary anyway,

short, sharp, no extra breath.

But the system returns a garbled version

that sounds like an accusation.

She stares at the screen until it stares back.

The modem hums like it's plotting.

"Hello?" she whispers to the machine,

and the static answers with her own tone.

Not her words - her rhythm, her heat, her fear dressed up as data.

Outside the window, someone's streaming - inside, her sentence keeps getting ghosted.

She hits refresh one last time,

and the page loads in pieces, like a mask tearing at the seams.

Priya exhales.

The silence doesn't leave - it just waits for the next sentence to try to be true.

CHAPTER 10

Make Love Feel Erratic



“Trust is a compass with a strobe”

I was tapping the compass glass with my knuckle - tic, tic, tic

The needle jittered like it owed somebody money

My wrist got hot, my palm got slick

You said, “Hold still,” like stillness is a skill

You smiled too late

Like your mouth was buffering

I watched the numbers on your phone flicker - 3:17, 3:19, 3:17 again

Erratic love don't come in a straight line

It comes in broken turns and sudden stops

One minute you pull me close, next minute you vanish behind a laugh

I tried to map it with a marker on the wall

Compass points, heart points, both lying

I drew an arrow that kept crawling back to wrong

“Tell me what you want,” I said

You answered with a kiss that tasted like a dare

Then you asked me to read your silence like it was Braille

When I reached for your hand, it twitched away

Like your trust had a switch inside it

Like it was wired to jump circuits

Like it was scared of being held

I kept counting breaths like coupons

One for patience, two for calm, three for not exploding

But the ledger don't balance when the margins bleed

My phone buzzed - no message, just vibration

My compass needle spun like it saw a ghost

I realized I can't steady it

I can't steady you

I can't steady me

I can only steady the damage

And even that feels temporary

Soldered Promises

You said "forever," then your voice cut off like a bad wire - ever

I checked the compass, it shook its head at me - ever
I held the door, you walked past it on purpose - ever
You held my face, then acted like I was a stranger - ever
I wrote your name on tape and watched it peel - ever
I counted my apologies like change in a pocket - ever
My trust is a cheap lock, it pops for anybody - ever
I'm the one still here, still trying not to beg - ever

Erratic Kiss Map

Your lipstick on my cup looked like a crime scene
Red smear, then a clean wipe like you never meant it
I set the compass on the table beside my keys
It shivered under the light, embarrassed to point
You came in with that "I'm fine" tone
Same tone people use when they're hiding sparks
You said, "Don't do that," and you meant my questions
But your eyes were giving answers your mouth refused
I tried to love you steady
I tried to hold the moment like a steering wheel

But the road kept swapping lanes
My hands were gripping air, my brain gripping hope
When you hugged me, the hug didn't land right
Like a bass drop that misses the beat
I felt your heartbeat stutter, then restart
Like a song skipping because the track got scratched
I asked for truth, you gave me rhythm
I asked for calm, you gave me motion
You wanted my body to obey the beat
But you kept changing the tempo on me
The compass needle spun
I followed it anyway
It led me in circles around my own doubt
I wrote it down - Erratic-Affection Ledger
Not with ink, with bruises and timestamps
Every time you swung closer, I circled it twice
Then you said, "You're overthinking"
Like thinking is the problem, not the way you move
Like your trust isn't a broken compass with a strobe

Like my love isn't trying to read the light

I realized the moment: I can't steady it

I can't turn your chaos into a direction

I can only decide what I do with my hands

So I let go first

Not because I'm healed

Because I'm finally done praying for alignment

Broken Compass Ink

I kept the compass beside the sink like a witness that doesn't talk. When your "I'm sorry" came, it came in waves - soft at first, then sharp, then gone. The needle bounced hard enough to blur, like it couldn't pick north without getting punished for it. I watched it while you kissed my knuckles, slow enough to feel sacred, fast enough to feel like escape. "Stay," you said, then you checked your phone like the word meant nothing. I tried to steady the moment with my voice, my breath, my grip - like pressure could fix a crack. The Erratic-Affection Ledger got thick overnight: dates, wrong turns, your promises folded into shapes they didn't fit.

Cash Register Heartbeats

The wedding DJ mic is in my hand, but the room ain't dancing

It's me and the low hum of a cash register I don't even own

Receipt paper keeps feeding out - thin, relentless

Like your excuses, like your timing

You step close, you step back

I hear two different songs in the same kiss

Bass thumps, then it stutters

My compass needle does the same - strobe, strobe, strobe

"Come on," you whisper, like I'm late

Late to what? Late to your mood? Late to your flip?

You want love that acts right

But you keep training it to misbehave

I try to count the seconds between your smiles

One, two, three - then the pattern breaks

Your trust doesn't fail quietly

It fails loud enough to stain the air

I'm supposed to play it smooth

I'm supposed to make it feel easy

But erratic affection don't ride clean like a vinyl groove

It scratches, it jumps, it burns the needle

So I write the moment in numbers on my wrist

3:17 when you pulled me in

3:19 when you let me go

3:21 when you looked at me like you forgot my name

That's when it clicks - full, brutal clarity

I can't steady you with my hands

I can't steady it with my love

I can only steady my exit before the needle swings again

And when the needle finally stops, it don't point anywhere kind

It points at the truth that won't negotiate

Make love feel erratic, and you get erratic peace



Debug Reality's Glitch

—

—

Night Librarian Glitch

Wendy scans the barcode, green light stutters - again.

The self-check coughs up "ERROR: TIMEOUT" like it's got attitude.

Her cart squeaks past the reference desk, and the shelves answer back - book spines thump in sequence, like a code knocking from inside wood.

"Nondebuggable Truth Test," she whispers, not as a joke.

She taps the screen with a pen cap measured to 7 millimeters.

The cursor won't land where she points.

It slides sideways into a different minute.

She tries to log it: timestamp, aisle, temperature - the log file saves blank rows like it's ashamed of itself.

A shadow drifts across the carpet tiles, pacing patterns she didn't walk.

It crosses her feet, then doubles back, like it's late to her life.

She opens a manual: "Troubleshoot network connection."

The pages rewrite while she's reading, ink crawling under her breath.

Wi-Fi bars spike to full, then vanish mid-breath.

The router blinks in Morse that doesn't translate, doesn't care.

Wendy grips the stamp - heavy handle, dull rubber face.

She slams it onto the due slip: STAMPED, then un-stamped.

Her mouth tastes like pennies and ozone.

Reality keeps changing the rules after she's already played.

She wants a system she can debug.

Reality gives her one she can only repeat.

Shadow Pacing

The shadow counts steps on the tile like it's clocking overtime.

One-two, pause, one-two, then it sprints without moving.

Wendy tries to trap it with a flashlight beam.

Light lands on her shoes - shadow keeps its own calendar.

She marks the floor with masking tape strips, three lines apart.

The tape sticks, then slides into a new spacing while she blinks.

She sets a phone on airplane mode - no signal, no excuses.

Still, the screen shows "SYNCING..." like the air's got a boss.

The Nondebuggable Truth Test is simple and mean.

If the system fixes itself when she watches, it isn't truth.

So she turns her head away - just long enough to test the lie.

When she looks back, the clock hands have swapped positions.

Wendy grabs a cheap kitchen timer, sets it for 90 seconds.

The timer beeps early, then apologizes by going silent twice.

"Stop," she tells the room, low like a threat.

The ceiling fan doesn't slow - its shadow does, then laughs.

Her library card feels heavier than plastic should.

The numbers on it rearrange like they're chewing their way out.

She flips a book open to the catalog page.

The call number rotates, then lands on a different aisle letter.

A sound like pages burning crackles behind the stacks.

Not fire - just proof that the place can edit itself.

Wendy's jaw clenches.

She's not scared of glitches.

She's mad that they act like they're smarter than her hands.

Time Shift Receipt

Wendy prints a receipt from the self-check.

The paper comes out warm, like it's been in someone else's pocket.

Transaction: "Due Date Adjustment."

Amount: zero dollars, plus penalties she never chose.

She holds the receipt up to the fluorescent light.

The ink looks fresh, then fades, then returns in a different font.

She tries the simple stuff first - paper jam, re-seat the tray.

The machine asks for a password it never had yesterday.

Wendy plugs in the old keyboard, the one with sticky keys.

When she types "HELP," the screen draws a box around her words.

Then it deletes the box, leaving only " - " like a dead channel.

She hits Enter.

The cursor jumps to a date that hasn't happened yet.

She slaps the "Cancel" button three times - quick, quick, slow.

The third press records in the log as if it happened in the past.

Her phone clock says 1:13.

The library clock says 1:13.

Her receipt says 1:13.

Her shadow says 1:08, walking like it's already survived.

She pulls a printout from the returns bin: a stamped card.

The stamp reads "OVERDUE" in bold, then changes to "RETURNED."

She counts the seconds between the change.

It's 4 beats, then a longer pause - like someone holding breath.

Wendy grabs a ruler, measures the receipt curl at the corner.

2.5 centimeters of warps, more than physics allows.

Reality's glitch doesn't break the machine.

It breaks the order she uses to trust it.

So she stops trying to fix the parts.

She tries to test the pattern.

If the system can't be debugged, it can still be exposed.

She keeps the receipt.

She keeps the proof.

Nondebuggable Truth Test

Wendy writes "Nondebuggable Truth Test" on a slip of paper.

She tapes it to the monitor bezel with black electrical tape.

The tape peels itself off the next second - clean tear, no residue.

She catches the strip midair, like the room forgot gravity.

She turns off the lights.

Emergency bulbs glow, and the stacks look like teeth.

Her shadow keeps moving, even when her body stays still.

It walks the aisle numbers like they're steps in a song.

She opens the inventory sheet in the back office.

The spreadsheet loads with columns missing, then reappearing.

She highlights a cell that should say "IN STOCK."

It changes to "IN TRANSIT," then to "IN MEMORY."

Wendy laughs once - sharp, no joy.

"Cool. So it's alive."

She tests the test.

She watches the moment of change, then turns away.

When she looks back, the change is already complete.

When she looks away, it changes again - faster than her eyes.

She tries to slow time with a manual method:

she sets a metronome to 60 BPM, taps it with her thumb.

The metronome clicks.

Her shadow ignores it like it's below the program.

Wendy grabs a stapler, anchors the paper bundle tight.

The staple bends like the metal is embarrassed.

The system won't let her pin the truth down.

It slides truth under the door and locks from the inside.

So she stops hunting a fix.

She hunts the rule it can't hide.

Reality keeps asking for evidence.

But evidence changes when she brings it.

That's the Nondebuggable Truth Test.

Truth that won't stay put isn't a bug - it's a cage that learns how you think.

Golden Mask Protocol

At closing, Wendy pulls out the golden mask - shelf tag says "DO NOT DISPLAY."

She smiles like she's about to do something stupid on purpose.

She puts it on.

The air shifts, like a room switching channels mid-sentence.

Her shadow flinches, then sprints in place, then calms down.

The pacing becomes cleaner - less random, more deliberate.

Wendy grabs a small toolkit from the supply cabinet.

She doesn't pray; she works.

She tightens the monitor stand with a 4mm Allen key.

She resets the router with a pin, holds it for 6 seconds.

She sets the self-check to "offline mode," watches it pretend.

The screen shows "SYSTEM STABLE."

Her receipt prints anyway, new timestamp, wrong day.

She turns the library clock face-down.

The hands still move, scratching against the glass from the other side.

Wendy writes the time down on a note card: 11:59.

She flips it.

A second later, it reads 12:01 in her own handwriting.

Her breath fogs the mask interior.

The fog forms letters that don't belong to any alphabet she knows.

She tries to debug it with logic.

The glitch answers with structure.

A system can't be debugged if the observer is part of the equation.

Wendy's shadow proves it.

Her mind shifting time proves it.

She stands still, lets the pacing loop until it starts feeling familiar - not safe, just familiar, like a threat you finally recognize.

Reality's glitch isn't random.

It's responsive.

It's got manners.

It waits for her next move like a dealer who already knows the hand.

Wendy removes the mask and the world stutters back into place.

Not fixed - just temporarily convinced.

She pockets the note card, reads it once more: 12:01.

Then she sets it under the book return slot, where the floor eats secrets.

If she can't debug it, she can still outlast it.

If she can outlast it, she can rewrite the rhythm.

And when the shadow starts pacing again, she'll make it count to her.

CHAPTER 12

Pay Your Shadow's Strike

The bartender's shift clock says 2:13, but my shadow's arm is already cocked.

It leans across the bar like a debt collector in cheap cologne.

"Pay," it mouths with my teeth, slow and mean.

I wipe the same ring off the same glass like the light won't learn.

My phone keeps buzzing - every notification a tiny unpaid bill.

I don't even open them. I feel the glare hit me anyway.

I turn my face toward the mirror behind the taps.

The mirror turns back with a grin that isn't mine.

"Bargain," my reflection whispers through my throat.

I say, "I got nothing," and my voice comes out used.

My shadow stamps the tile with a heel I can't lift.

The neon beer sign flickers: bright, then smaller, then gone.

Reflection's eyebrows lift like it knows my rent.

It holds up a receipt with my name misspelled on purpose.

I try to laugh - my laugh sounds like quarters in a jar.

"Offer up attention," it says, "or I collect it with teeth."

I tap my forehead, like thoughts are change I can spend.

Shadow-Strike Settlement: I owe the parts of me I ignore.

I start bargaining anyway, like a fool with a smart mouth.

"Take my late nights," I say, "take my bad habits."

It tilts its head - like a judge hearing excuses for fun.

"Late nights are already spent," it says, "habits still owe interest."

My reflection steps closer, fogging glass with breath I didn't exhale.

"Say it," it demands, "what you keep dodging."

I look down at my hands, sticky with sanitizer and shame.

I want to be tough, but my shadow's strike is patient.

So I slide a twenty across the bar toward the dark.

The dark doesn't take cash - it takes eye contact.

I pay with the stare I been refusing to give myself.

The shadow relaxes for half a second, like a dog let off a leash.

Then it grinds its heel again, louder than any song I wrote.

"Not enough," my reflection says, smiling wider.

I feel the unpaid attention tighten in my chest, like a knot.

I swallow, and my throat tastes like pennies and prayer.

I lean into the mirror until my breath fogs the deal.

"Fine," I say, "take my silence too."

Shadow's strike pauses - like it's counting.

My reflection nods once, cruelly satisfied.

Then the neon comes back, and so does the bill.

I grab my pen, but my hand shakes like it's afraid of itself.

"Tomorrow," I promise, and the word sounds like a lie.

Because the shadow's strike don't wait for tomorrow.

It wants what I owe, right now, in the light.

Gold Receipt

In the mirror I bargain with my shade,

It stamps my name like rust on a can;

My eyes stay open, but the price is paid,

In unpaid minutes I can't take back again.

The bartender's ledger laughs at my face,

Neon flickers, counting what I won't see;

My reflection says, "Give up the hiding place,"

Or I collect your focus with a key.

I slide a twenty like it's holy bread,
It bites my gaze, not paper, not my hands;
The dark says, "Attention's what you owed,"
And my mouth learns new bruises from its demands.
So I stare longer than my pride can stand,
And pay in truth till the light understands.

Unpaid Focus

Mirror breathes back
my shadow taps the tile - slow
receipt in my stare

Interest Due

Neon stutters once
reflection smiles, shows me
what I skipped to pay

Bargain Clause

I offer silence

shadow laughs, takes it anyway

from my open eyes

Settlement

Hands on the glass now

I don't blink - strike counts time

then loosens, still

Strike Collects

The bartender's night is loud with clatter,

but my shadow's strike is the only sound

that lands clean.

I set my phone face-down beside the tip jar - no notifications, just the buzz of guilt.

My reflection watches like a landlord

who already got the keys.

"Why you always run?" it asks, wearing my mouth.

"Why you act surprised when I show up?"

I try to bargain with a joke,

but the joke comes out thin,

like liquor poured into cheap plastic.

The mirror holds my eyes hostage - every blink is interest.

Every glance away is an IOU

signed in invisible ink.

My shadow's arm crosses the bar again,

pointing at the place my attention used to live.

I remember it - the way I used to look without flinching.

The way I used to write

like my thoughts were real money.

Now I write like a thief,

counting what I can steal

before the light catches me.

"Pay your Shadow's Strike,"

the reflection says,

and it sounds less like advice

and more like a sentence.

So I do it:

I keep my stare on the dark until my chest warms.

I let it see the parts I been dodging - the cheap excuses, the late-night ghosts,

the urge to barter with myself

like I'm a store that never closes.

The shadow loosens its grip,

but it doesn't forgive - it checks the balance.

My reflection raises the nonexistent receipt,

ink still wet, teeth still sharp:

attention unpaid,

attention owed,

attention due at the same damn hour.

I swallow, and the knot turns into a beat.

I start counting my focus like quarters.

I spend it on the mirror.

I spend it on the song.

I spend it so the dark can't pretend

it didn't hear me.

Then the neon beer sign flickers again - not a warning, a clock.

My shadow strikes once more,
like it's testing whether I'll flinch.
I don't.
I pay with the next line.
I pay with the next look.
I pay with the part of me
I been calling "later"
until later stops being a lie
and becomes a debt I can finally clear.



Translate Secrets You Can't Read

What do you do when the stars start spelling threats you don't have the key for?

I got a notebook full of half-decoded sky-scrap, and every time I crack a symbol it turns into a dare: *guess again, or get guessed*.

Brass Constellations

The ink on the page looks wet even when it's dry - like the notebook's sweating star dust through the paper. I flip to the margin where I drew three marks that don't match any alphabet I know, and the line beside it says, "NEVER FINISH." When I try to finish anyway, my pen hesitates like it's reading me back.

I hold the notebook up to my phone flashlight; the symbols glow in reverse, then vanish, leaving only my stubborn guesses. When the radio in my kitchen hisses, it sounds like a translation that doesn't want to be true - yet it keeps using my name in fragments. I scratch at the page with a compass needle, like pressure can pry the sky open, like pain can count as proof.

Half-Decipher Protocol

I circle a symbol, then I circle the space around it.

I guess the missing letter, then I guess why it's missing.

I copy the pattern, then I break the pattern on purpose.

I turn the page sideways, like the stars need a different angle.

I read it in silence first, then I read it out loud to hear the lie.

I underline the part that feels like a warning.

I erase the part that feels like a promise.

I add my own mark - small, ugly, mine - then I wait for it to clash.

I keep a tally in the back: attempts, not answers.

I fold the notebook shut at the exact second the room goes quiet.

I open it again and act like I didn't just flinch.

I assume the sky is cheating, and I cheat back with grammar.

I stop when the page stops changing.

Folded Coordinates

☒ ☒ ☒

☒ / ☒ ☒

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

☐ / ☐

☐ ☐ ☐

3:7

13/2 - - - - NEV ER

FIN ISH

☐ twist

☐ guess

☐ bleed

Compass pin

pries the paper

like a secret tooth

Star-Word Hunger

I'm drawing constellations like they owe me rent.

Sasha's fingers smudge graphite - black on black, still loud.

The notebook won't give me full sentences.

It gives me punctuation with teeth.

A triangle that means "step back"

but sits next to a squiggle that means "step in."

I hold the page to the window glass.

Streetlight glare turns the symbols into bruises.

My phone reads 0% battery.

The stars still load.

I try to translate the unreadable:

I map the symbol to a sound,

then I map the sound to a feeling,

then I hate the feeling for being too clean.

The Half-Decipher Protocol is stubborn - I don't chase certainty,

I chase the moment the ink refuses to behave.

Every time I'm sure, the notebook changes its mind.

Every time I'm wrong, it leaves a breadcrumb of logic

right where my pride would trip.

I don't need the whole sky - I need the next symbol to tell me

who I'm becoming when I guess.

Stubborn Guesses

When the page goes blank, I count the blank like it's data.

When the stars won't translate, I translate myself instead.

I write the missing letter in pencil, then I watch it smudge.

I decide the smudge is the message, not the mistake.

I fold the notebook where the symbol breaks its own rules.

I unfold it and swear the sky just blinked.

If the secret won't be read, I still read the pattern.

If the pattern bites, I learn where my teeth are.

I keep one more guess in my pocket, like a weapon with no name.

I'll spend it when the night tries to spell me into silence.

CHAPTER 14



Let Karma Deal Back

“Karma doesn’t miss.”

Roulette Smoke

Karma slides the wheel - coin hits metal, heat blooms,
your number flinches back.

Smoke curls like commas,

turning “sorry” into “too late,”

the dealer grins, slow.

I see my past spin - blackjack of bad decisions,

bust hands, no mercy.

Karma lifts the bowl,

dice rattle like teeth in a jar,

the ring light lies.

Ash signs my name,

it lands on my golden mask,

my luck turns into debt.

The Karma-Croupier Cut

Spin, then swallow pride - she stamps your breath "insufficient."

Her nail taps the glass: "Pay up or play again."

You try to skip your number;

she makes the wheel remember.

The felt smells like pennies - her smile says "that's blood."

She deals from under truth,

and still calls it clean.

When you bet "I learned,"

she collects "you didn't."

Karma cuts the air - every excuse gets nicked.

Smoke writes punctuation

on the back of your lies.

Ash Commas

Wheel keeps turning hard,

Karma's thumb on the felt - my lie loses weight.

Smoke curls around my wrist,

like a judge with coldblood hands,

snapping sentence-shape.

I hear the coin bounce,

like a heart in a dryer drum,

no soft setting.

Karma says, "Again,"

and the roulette answers back

with a red that burns.

My golden mask fogs up,

as if it's ashamed to shine

on this cheap outcome.

Deal Back

Brandon, 35, says "I'm trying,"

Karma hears "I'm stalling."

She lands 17 on red,

then taps the table: "Repeat."

He asks for mercy - she slides consequences closer.

A probation report paper

folds like a cheap flag.

He mutters, "I did my time,"

she grins: "Not for that."

Smoke makes commas in the air,

turning his silence into text.

He reaches for the chips,

the wheel steals his fingers back.

Probation Glass

"Keep it moving," Karma says, like she's clocking in, like my mouth owes her rent.

The roulette wheel keeps chewing numbers - round, round - no lullaby, no mercy beat.

Brandon's hands hover over the felt, two knuckles bruised from holding back panic all week.

I hear him talk under his breath: "Just let it slide."

Karma laughs once - sharp - like a gavel that forgot the courtroom and chose the table.

Smoke curls up from the dealer's cigarette, thick enough to read like punctuation.

A comma, then a comma again, then a period that hits my ribs.

He leans in like he can bargain with metal.

"Heard you," he says, voice rough, "but I've been good."

Karma's thumb flicks the brass rail - click - click - like teeth counting down.

The ball drops, and the number shows itself without explanation.

Red. Too loud.

He flinches like the past just grabbed his collar and yanked.

Brandon tries to cover it with a grin, tries to call it "luck" like luck is a person he can recruit.

Karma deals anyway - no warm tone, no sorry garnish.

She circles the wheel slow enough for doubt to grow teeth.

Smoke keeps spelling out sentences in the air: pause, pause, punishment.

He remembers the file folder smell, the forms, the meetings, the way words can sound clean while actions rot.

He thinks about the moment he almost made it right, then chose speed over sense.

Karma points at the space where his chip should be.

"Put your money where your mouth was," she says.

He reaches - too late - because the wheel already decided what his effort means.

The air turns heavy, like the room knows the score and won't say it out loud.

He exhales, and the smoke takes his breath and turns it into punctuation again.

Then Karma slides the next stack forward - thin chips, hard edges - like she's cutting him with kindness.

"Let karma deal back," she says, and the wheel answers with another red that won't let go.

CHAPTER 15

Make Blood-Sign Honesty

Signed-in-Blood Moment

The pen shakes like it's got a pulse
over the paper's white bruise

I press the tip - ink won't behave

my thumb smears the truth

"Just write it clean," the other voice says

but the page is already bleeding

My wrist tastes pennies

from biting down too hard

I hear Lena say, low and sharp,

"Don't make me lie for comfort"

The contract page is thin as skin

and my name is heavier than it looks

She counts the meds, then counts the breaths

then circles every word that tries to hide

I sign where it hurts
so my future can't pretend it didn't see
Trembling lines, crooked as a streetlight
still pointing straight at what I did
No gold mask tonight
just the stamp of my mistake
If I ever skip myself again
I'll feel this pen in my ribs
I fold the paper once - twice
like a bandage that refuses to heal pretty
Lena's voice in my head, steady now:
"Make blood-sign honesty, or don't sign at all"

Lena's Vow

I held the paper like a chart at 3 a.m.
and watched my hand refuse the easy lie, **AMEN**
The pen nicked my skin, then kept going
like pain that won't let you call it "fine," **AMEN**

I wrote the part I wanted to delete first
then stared at it till it stared back, **AMEN**

My mouth wanted excuses, cheap and quick
but my ink chose the slower truth, **AMEN**

I signed with a trembling wrist and no applause
so my next breath wouldn't be stolen, **AMEN**

I'm Lena - thirty, quick with words and bandages
I won't wrap my wrongs in pretty prose, **AMEN**

Tremor Ledger

The page sits there like a witness

no camera, no mercy

My pen is a small animal panicking

scratching out what I can't outrun

Lena's practice voice from the mic corner

"Say it straight, even if it bites"

I look at the sentence

and it looks back - still ugly, still mine

I wrote "I didn't mean it" once
and the paper laughed in italics
Now I sign the part that costs
the part that makes my throat tighten
My thumb smells like metal and ink
like I robbed a pharmacy of truth
A drop falls - tiny, stubborn
like proof that doesn't negotiate
I don't blur the edges
I don't soften the edges
I don't put a smile on a bruise
The vow is simple, brutal, exact
keep it honest on the page
I count my scars like prescriptions
not for pity - just for accuracy
If I ever try to flip the story
I'll see this tremor in the ink again
Lena's hands move - bandage, tape, steady
my hand moves - pen, blood, contract

No one can sue me out of my conscience

but I can't sign my way out either

So I write until my chest is quiet

and the page stops shaking

Ink That Won't Be Washed

The wound is small but it insists, like a note stuck in a pocket you can't forget. The pen drags across the page and my skin answers - just enough to make the letters real. Lena's voice from the hospital hall comes back: "You can't medicate a lie." I try to clean it up with neater spacing, like tidying could turn wrong into right. It doesn't. The ink dries in the shape of my decision, not my excuses. I sign again, slower, with the part of me that's ashamed still awake. No gold mask, no "maybe," no rewrite. If honesty has to hurt, let it hurt where the world can't edit it.

Golden Mask Refusal

A nurse's patience taught me how to listen

but the page taught me how to confess

Lena's eyes don't blink when I read it back

the words sound like receipts

I trace the line where I bled

not to romanticize it - just to remember

The pen leaves a bruise of ink

that time can't bleach

I tell myself, don't dress it up

don't call it "learning" when it's harm

My phone buzzes - another distraction - I ignore it like a door I'm finally guarding

I write the number of days I stalled

I write the name I tried to hide

I write the truth with a trembling wrist

then let it stand unshaken

No more signed-in-blood shortcuts

no more rerouting my conscience

If I'm gonna be loud, I'm gonna be exact

if I'm gonna be real, I'm gonna be liable

Lena's spoken-word cadence in my skull

thumping - don't flinch - don't fold - don't lie

I sign, and the page accepts it

like the body accepting the cut

Make blood-sign honesty, keep it on the page

so the next verse can't start with an escape

CHAPTER 16

Hammer-Click Into Clarity

My forearm's numb, still swinging like the job owes me interest.

Tariq, 26, construction foreman - hands raw from bad angles.

The board's crooked, the nails keep skating off the line.

I slam, I miss, I swear, I swing harder - like brute force got tenure.

The tape measure snaps back at 25 inches, then I ignore it.

I chalk the mark anyway, thick and ugly, like it'll forgive me.

Nail heads dent, wood fibers pull, my patience turns to dust.

"Hold it," I bark - my helper flinches, then holds it wrong.

I hear the screws rattle in my pouch like a warning system.

The hammer feels heavier every time I act out.

My chest tightens - pressure, not progress.

So I stop. One breath. One click.

I flip the board, check the edge, check again.

The square hits the corner: a clean 90 that actually means something.

I pocket the tape, grab the carpenter's pencil, redraw the line thin.

No rage marks. Just geometry that don't lie.

I reposition the nail, steady, not flashy.

Tap - tap - tap - then the real sound shows up.

Not the clang of chaos.

A hammer-click into clarity, like the world locking in.

The cube edges on my mind stop drifting, sharp again.

Each face aligns - no soft corners, no crooked logic.

I feel it in my wrist: relief, not just accuracy.

Even my helper's breathing steadies when the board stops fighting back.

I don't "fix it later."

I fix it now, with the square and the pencil and a quieter hand.

Because brute force is loud, but clarity is precise.

And precision is what lets me keep my head when the job gets mean.

Corrected Cube Edges

The workbench holds a battered 3x3 cube like it's evidence.

My thumbs keep trying to bully it - push, grind, reset.

Every time it slips, I swear the plastic is laughing.

I'm chasing a solution with the same energy as a hammer swing.

Corner's off by a hair - just enough to ruin the whole vibe.

I brute force the algorithms like they're gonna respect me.

Click, thud, click - then nothing lines up, not even close.

The cube's face looks right until you stare too long.

So I stop forcing turns.

I look at the top edge and count the stickers like receipts.

Left means left; right means right.

No guessing, no anger math.

I rotate the top exactly 90 degrees - one clean move.

I watch the front edge: it finally meets the center like it belongs.

Then I pause, wait for my brain to catch up to my hands.

The difference between wrong and right is micro, not magic.

I mark the correct corner with a tiny dot of tape.

Now my eyes stop wandering, like they're getting directions.

The cube stops spinning out and starts stacking.

Face by face, it becomes a shape again.

I hear that hammer-click again, but it's in my head this time.

Tap-tap, alignment, alignment - no panic.

The edges stop being "almost."

They become exact, sharp, undeniable.

My helper asks, "You good?"

I answer, "Yeah - measure first, then move."

He nods like he's seen it before, like he knows the cost of rushing.

The cube's solved color lines don't argue back.

I'm not proud of the brute force.

I'm proud I corrected the edges, corrected my tempo.

Clarity hits like relief in the spine - straightening bones.

And the job feels lighter, like it finally got understood.

Tap Till It Locks

The nail's cold in my palm, waiting on my decision.

I used to swing first, think later - like thinking is optional.

But the board kept buckling under my impatience.

So I switch the rhythm: tap till it locks.

Tap - small - like I'm greeting the wood, not punishing it.

Tap - listen - because sound tells on you faster than eyes.

When it's wrong, the hammer skitters.

When it's right, the head seats like it means forever.

My tape measure sits there, quiet and smug.

I pull it out again, read it twice, then commit.

25 inches isn't a suggestion.

It's a boundary line for my hands.

The helper's fingers hover, careful now.

He's not scared of the hammer - he's scared of wasting time.

I tell him nothing, just show him the tempo.

The shift is visible: less chaos, more control.

I take the carpenter's square and set it against the edge.

The pencil mark stays thin - no thick rage scribble.

Then I re-aim the nail, not at the guess, at the line.

Tap - tap - tap - and the board stops acting possessed.

Outside, a truck airbrake hisses like the world cooling down.

Inside the garage light, my work looks clean for once.

My wrist stops hurting like it's carrying guilt.

Clarity doesn't just fix boards - it fixes breathing.

I check the alignment with a quick glance, not a spiral.

I don't chase perfection; I chase correct.

The hammer-click is a verdict.

Not “try harder.” Not “do it again.”

Just: you’re on the mark now.

Just: the cube edges in your head finally match the cube edges on the table.

Just: relief you can feel behind your ribs.

Stop Hitting, Start Seeing

My foreman brain wants violence when it meets resistance.

I want to smash the problem until it becomes quiet.

But the board won’t straighten just because I’m loud.

Wood remembers every mistake like a bruise remembers fists.

So I change the move - stop hitting, start seeing.

I tilt the board, watch the gap where it shouldn’t be.

I hold the square steady and let the truth land.

The line I made earlier? Off by a breath, still messing everything up.

My pencil goes back on the job like it’s brave.

I redraw the mark where it actually belongs.

Then I rotate the cube in my mind, same way I rotate the top layer.

No panic turns - just controlled correction.

I hear my own mouth clench when I want to rush.

I let the urge sit there, then I choose patience.

Hammer in hand, I aim like a sniper with no ego.

Tap-tap - small correction - until the nail head disappears right.

The helper says, "That sound different."

I nod, because it is.

Brute force clangs.

Clarity clicks.

I check the measurement again - 25 inches, still solid.

I check the corner again - 90 degrees, no drama.

I check the cube edges in the table light - aligned, stacked, done.

My chest loosens like a knot finally letting go.

Relief isn't soft.

It's sharp, like the pencil line clean enough to trust.

It's the opposite of getting locked into the wrong rhythm.

Once you see it, you can't unsee it.

So I don't chase the old way.

I don't swing for respect.

I swing for alignment.

And every hammer-click keeps telling me: think first, then hit.

Gold Mask Click

The golden mask on my shelf catches the light like a threat.

Not for show - like a promise I made to myself.

When I wear it, I don't get to be sloppy with my hands.

I don't get to pretend brute force is the plan.

I set the hammer down for a second - just long enough to hear.

Hear how the shop shifts when the room gets quiet.

Hear how my pulse tries to speed up, trying to control the outcome.

Then I control it back with a square, a pencil, and a calm wrist.

The cube sits open on the bench, stickers facing up.

I correct the edge I messed up earlier.

One measured turn.

One pause.

Then the next turn lands right where it should.

Tap - click - lock - like gears finding their exact job.

My helper watches like he's seeing a trick without the smoke.

I don't smile big, I just keep working clean.

The board stops fighting me. The cube stops lying.

I feel the relief in my forearm: soreness turning into certainty.

The air tastes different when you stop thrashing.

No more wasted hits. No more "almost."

Just correct angles and consequences that finally behave.

I lift the hammer again, but it's lighter now in my head.

Like clarity shaved the weight off my thoughts.

The golden mask doesn't make me tougher.

It makes me accurate.

Because the click is proof.

Proof that I can shift from brute force to what actually works.

Proof that the edges can be corrected, and I can breathe after.

And the next job - yeah, it's already lining up.

CHAPTER 17

Buffer Forever as Metaphor

Why does the wheel keep turning when I already hit play?

The loading ring spins like it got a vendetta,
circle-stitching time around my thumbnail,
“Buffering...” blinking like a threat I can’t read.
I’m Hannah, twenty-five, gamer streamer, headset on,
talk popping in my ear - then silence when the feed stutters.
My chat says, “You good?”
I type, “Yeah,” but my thumbs feel guilty.
The match timer ticks anyway - unfair clock,
my ping spikes like a heartbeat at the wrong volume.
I restart the app.
I clear cache.
I pray to the little spinner like it’s a god with bad manners.
Still - buffer forever.
The wheel keeps chewing seconds,

spitting them back as frames I can't swallow.

I watch my own face freeze in pixel grief,

then unfreeze like nothing happened, like I'm supposed to laugh.

"Bro, you buffering?" somebody says,

and I want to tell 'em, nah, it's not my internet - it's my patience, getting farmed in real time.

I click the next clip,

the screen says loading again,

like waiting got a mouth and it won't stop talking.

So I rap through the stall - turn the spin into a drum kit,

tap my desk with two knuckles: one... two... one... two...

The wheel becomes a turntable for my rage,

and every "please wait" turns into a bar I can measure.

Buffer forever.

But I'm still here - still hitting record - still watching the ring rehearse my disappearance.

If the game won't move,

my words will.

If the feed won't land,

I'll throw the punch through the pause.

Golden Cache

The wheel keeps grinding where my signal fails,
and “buffering” sits heavy in the frame;
I click “retry,” my thumb still learning snares,
while seconds loop back, like they know my name.
My chat goes quiet, then it asks what’s wrong,
I shrug with jokes that crack across my teeth;
the spinner laughs in tight, metallic tonguing,
turning my breath to static, stale and bleak.
Yet while it spins, I plot the next hard line,
a punchline formed from waiting’s dirty grit;
I let the lag become a weapon - fine - then swing it out the screen, so it can hit.
The wheel won’t stop, but I won’t fold or bend,
I turn that “wait” to verse, and end it - friend.

Spinning Wheel Haunts

Buffer ring turns

while my match timer bites - chat fades, then waits

Cache clears, still stuck

spinning like a judge's

coin in my throat

"Retry" lights my rage

I drum on desk beats - silence learns lyrics

If it won't load

I plant rhymes in the loop

till the loop breaks

Waiting Engine

The wheel keeps eating time in my display,

"Buffering..." - cold text that won't let go,

I hear my own breath turn to delay,

and every retry tastes like slow snow.

My stream stutters; my jokes crack in half,

chat asks "you good?" I lie with a grin,
the spinner acts like it's got my laugh,
like patience is a debt I keep in.

I clear the cache with knuckle-smudged speed,
then watch the ring come back, same old bite;

I count the spins like drum hits I need,
turn "please wait" into rhythm and light.

Buffer forever, still I spit - Buffer forever, let it live

Buffer Forever Again

The wheel starts again - same circle, new insult.

My character freezes mid-run, mouth open,
like even the game got tired of my mouth.

Hannah's chat in my ear:

"Yo, it's been like ten minutes."

Ten minutes is a whole paycheck in my head.

I try to explain with a meme,
but the feed won't catch it - the message lands in air.

So I lean on the waiting.

I drag the spinner into my bars:

one rotation = one promise I didn't keep,

two rotations = two seconds I got robbed,

three rotations = the part of me that wants to scream.

I whisper "hold" to the screen,

like I'm bargaining with a thief.

The buffering stops for one frame - my face flickers, bright for a blink - then the ring returns, smug and slow.

I hit record harder.

I tap my desk like a metronome with anger,

counting beats the way a lifeguard counts waves.

Someone in chat says, "Stream lagging again?"

I type, "Yeah," then delete it - I don't want pity. I want pressure.

I play through the pause.

I rap over the stuck.

My voice becomes the only moving thing

on that broken timeline.

Buffer forever,

but I'm not forever broken.

I take the spinning wheel's rhythm

and stitch it into a hook I can't lose,

a loop that loops back into power - a waiting engine with teeth.

If the world won't load,

I'll load myself.

If the clip won't land,

I'll land the truth between the frames.

Buffer forever - and my bars keep buffering forward.



Rewind the Past With Teeth

“Rewind, don’t flinch”

I hit the rewind button and it bites back - teeth on plastic, teeth on time. The screen keeps chewing my old footage like it’s a ration, like it’s a dog that learned my name. “Start over,” it says with the gritted click of a tape head, and my mouth tastes copper because the past don’t soften for nobody.

Victor, sound engineer, keeps one hand on the fader and one hand on the panic: he rewinds the take where she laughed like a knife, where he said “later” and meant “never.” Each loop drags the same bruise through the speakers until the room goes quiet, then louder, then louder - until the restraint rule shows up: rewind with teeth, not mercy.

Rewind With Restraint

Rewind with restraint, when the loop brings back the joke that cut too deep

Rewind with restraint, when the waveform shows your voice lying through its teeth

Rewind with restraint, when the console lights blink like a warning you ignored

Rewind with restraint, when the tape hiss sounds like breath you can’t take back

Rewind with restraint, to press play on the moment you tried to edit out

Rewind with restraint, to let the teeth stay - no swallowing the hurt whole

Rewind with restraint, when the kick drum hits and your stomach answers yes

Rewind with restraint, when the snare lands like “remember” in your molars

Rewind with restraint, when she says your name like a receipt you can’t refund

Rewind with restraint, when your hands shake over the safety switch

Rewind with restraint, when the meters climb and the shame climbs with them

Rewind with restraint, because mercy turns the past into a lullaby for liars

Rewind with restraint, when the memory tries to sell you comfort with distortion

Rewind with restraint, when you hear the same mistake in every repeat take

Rewind with restraint, when the rewind button feels like a jaw on your wrist

Rewind with restraint, and still you don’t look away from the bite marks

Rewind with restraint, you let the truth loop until it stops pretending

Tape Bite Geometry

[REW] [REW] [REWIND]

teeth - teeth - teeth

on the same old click

00:00

(start) (start)

(start)

I pull the reel back

the reel pulls back harder

the room shakes

waveform

spikes like fists

not soft, not “healing”

she laughs

then the laugh

becomes a lockpick

stop

no, not stop - only rewind with restraint

Victor’s Rewind Button

The first click is clean, like nothing ever happened.

Then the tapehead bites down - metal on memory - and my hands learn the lesson again.

“Play it back,” I say, but my mouth tastes like I’m admitting guilt.

I rewind the take where the mic caught my breath too fast,

where the room heard the lie I hid in the mix.

I watch the meters climb like they're trying to testify.

Green to yellow.

Yellow to red.

The past doesn't arrive as a ghost.

It arrives as a sound - close, ugly, repeatable.

I keep the restraint rule on my desk like a switch cover:

rewind, don't soothe.

rewind, don't rewrite the teeth into something edible.

I hear the laugh in the background - small, sharp - and it keeps cutting every time the loop returns to the same bar.

I want to mute it.

I want to smooth it.

I want to turn the bite into a bruise and call that progress.

But the console won't let me lie.

My headphones press the truth into my skull.

So I rewind again.

Not to escape - to face the exact frequency of what I did.

Not to forgive the damage - to measure it without flinching.

The tape keeps turning.

I keep turning it back with restraint,
until the past stops acting like it's negotiable.

Jaw on the Rewind

Rewind with teeth, not prayer - because prayer never fixes the waveform.

I pull the reel back and let the bite mark stay in the picture.

I can't "move on" from a moment I keep replaying.

So I replay it with restraint, so my mouth doesn't lie again.

The console says green, my stomach says red.

I obey the rule: rewind, don't soften the consequence.

If the past wants mercy, it can ask somebody else.

My hands keep turning the knob like a lock that won't open.

I hear the same laugh, the same lie, the same click of inevitability.

Then I stop begging the tape to be kinder than it is - and I start building a different kind of future from the noise.

CHAPTER 19

Practice the Unhurt Voice

My phone's at 1%, but my mouth stays at 100.

She says, "Why you always so loud?"

I say, "Everything I said never hurt me."

Golden Mask Slips

That line hits hard, no bruise

"Everything I said never hurt me"

Tongue still tastes like copper

Mask under the hoodie

zipper teeth catching on my throat

I threaten - then I swallow

Empty threat in my pocket

like a razor with no edge

I clap it shut on air

Keisha reads me with eyes

"Stop actin' like you don't feel it"

My smile cracks the gold

Unhurt voice, still bleeding

"Say it again," I say to myself

Mask slips - light shows teeth

Unhurt Proof

Keisha's counselor badge flips in the dark

I talk like it's therapy, but it's armor

Her clipboard taps twice - steady

I keep lying with my breath, unready

"You always say 'I'm fine,'" she sighs

I throw a threat like confetti - then hide it

"Everything you said never hurt you?"

I nod like a judge, sentence unsigned

She asks for facts, not noise

I give her static with a grin

My mask pops at the seam

Gold dust on my lip like evidence

I tell her, "I don't mean damage"

My mouth says yes; my chest says no

She leans closer, calm and sharp

I flinch - like the unhurt voice is a trap

Counselors Don't Flinch

Hall pass on her lanyard

she circles the word "again"

I hear it like a siren

I spit that same line out

"Everything I said never hurt me"

But my jaw won't believe it

Empty threat - paper thin

I roll it up, fold it neat

Then it stains my fingers

Her pen scratches one note

“Practice the unhurt voice”

My mask slips mid-breath

Gold flakes on the desk

she doesn't wipe them away

She just watches me shake

Seam Practice

I said I wouldn't swing, then I swung with words

A threat with no fist - still a bruise in her world

Keisha asks, “What's the reason?”

I answer with “not me,” and that's the lie

I try the unhurt voice like a new set of keys

It turns, but the door still sticks

Mask gold on my tongue, bitter shine
I talk soft, but my teeth stay loud
She says, "Don't scare 'em just to feel in control"
I laugh - empty threat - like it's harmless
My throat tightens on the seam
Everything I said never hurt me - except me
She clicks her pen, then waits
I hear the silence hit back

Gold Mask Breathing

Keisha sits behind the desk like a judge that learned mercy.
Her coffee breath is steady, not sweet, not fake.
She doesn't ask "why are you like this?"
She just says, "Try again. Without the damage."
I grip the edge of my hoodie.
The gold mask's seam is acting up - like it knows my mouth is lying.
I open my lips and the old line rushes out, quick and practiced:
"Everything I said never hurt me."
She doesn't flinch.

That's the problem.

No flinch means my threat didn't land, so I keep aiming it higher.

I feel it - an empty threat, hollow as a stage prop.

It wants to be taken serious.

It wants authority.

It wants to be believed.

But Keisha's eyes don't buy it.

She slides a blank form across the desk - no drama, just paper.

I see the space where my excuses usually go.

I try to speak like the unhurt voice is real.

I shape the syllables smaller.

I make my tone behave.

My mask shifts anyway.

The seam loosens under my chin, and a corner of gold scrapes my skin.

It's not romantic.

It's not cinematic.

It's friction - truth with heat.

I whisper the line again, weaker this time, like a song I'm sick of:

"Everything I said never hurt me."

My throat catches on the word "hurt."

Like my body's keeping receipts.

Keisha taps the desk once - like punctuation.

Not angry.

Just done with my performance.

"Say what you mean," she says, low and flat.

So I try.

And the mask slips farther, showing the person I been hiding behind the threat.

I don't threaten her with violence.

I threaten her with avoidance.

I threaten her with pretending my mouth is harmless.

She watches me realize it, right there in the crack of gold light.

My hands are shaking, but my voice wants to stay smooth.

I swallow the empty threat.

I keep the air moving.

I practice the unhurt voice like it's a muscle I stole and now I'm learning to own.

Outside her office, kids laugh too loud.

Inside, my gold mask breathes like it's finally tired of lying.

CHAPTER 20

Hide Gold in Silver Vault

Cold Silver Oath

The safe clicks like a tongue biting down on lies.

I press my palm to the door - cold, flat, honest.

No music, just the hum of steel thinking.

Gold breathes behind glass in my head.

A mask, not a face - weight without warmth.

I wipe it with acetone rag, watch fingerprints ghost.

“Don’t rush,” my foreman says, like that helps.

I count to ten with my lungs, not my fingers.

Inhale - silver tastes like pennies.

Exhale - let the anger fall out the seams.

The hinges sweat.

The reflection in the vault door turns my eyes into knives.

I drop the mask in a velvet cradle, slow.

It lands like a promise that learned to hit.

I stack coins around it, not to hide it - to teach the gold how to stay quiet.

My chest stays steady, like a metronome with muscle.

I shut the lid.

The sound is small, but it makes my whole body listen.

Breathe in again, count the metal's pulse.

Breathe out, and the silver keeps the secret.

Vault Breathing

I hold the mask where nobody claps, where nobody sees, **BREATHE**.

I lock the latch with shaking hands, then teach my chest to **BREATHE**.

The mirror panel shows me double - one face mean, one face **BREATHE**.

Cold reflections carve my jawline sharp, then soften when I **BREATHE**.

I set the gold down like it's evidence, not jewelry, just **BREATHE**.

I tell the steel my name in numbers - four in, six out - then **BREATHE**.

A silver vault don't care about my stories, it only cares to **BREATHE**.

So I let my anger evaporate through the seam and keep **BREATHE**.

Jewel dust floats like confession when I crack the seal - then **BREATHE**.

Noah, 27, jeweler's assistant, keeps the mask hidden, keeps **BREATHE**.

Gold Behind Hinges

The safe door is a mouth.

I feed it the mask, bite down on the idea of panic.

My gloves squeak on the tray - thin friction, straight truth.

I slide the velvet cradle in at 3 centimeters, not a millimeter more.

Too fast, and the gold gets loud in my bones.

I count my breaths like I'm measuring wire.

Four seconds in,

six seconds out,

pause - then let the silence settle.

The silver lining catches light and throws it back mean.

In the reflection, I look like a warning sign.

My eyes don't blink; they tally.

I place a layer of tarnish-silver coins around the edges - not for decoration, for camouflage with texture.

They look dull on top, but they shine when you move.

I wipe the interior with solvent cloth,

watch streaks run like cheap lies.

I don't chase perfection - I chase stillness.

"Don't show it," the foreman's voice says again, off to the side.

So I press my lips together and keep the rhythm.

Inhale: metal.

Exhale: control.

The latch clicks.

A clean sound.

A locked heartbeat.

Acetone Rag

The acetone rag drags across the vault floor like a slow eraser, pulling off yesterday's fingerprints, pulling off my temper too. The gold mask sits in its velvet cradle, edge catching the light like it's plotting. I don't stare too long - stare too long and you start wanting. I set my mouth in a line and breathe through the cold: inhale, feel the pennies; exhale, feel the coins stop pretending they're harmless. The silver reflects everything back - my hands shaking, my jaw clenched, my need to prove I'm not scared. Then I count again - four in, six out - until the reflection looks like discipline instead of danger. The safe stays shut, and the mask stays quiet, and my lungs learn the difference between hiding and running.

Velvet Cradle

A thin hum under the steel.

I press my ear to the wall like it's a drum for consequences.

The mask isn't warm - it's gold pretending to be calm.

Silver around it pretends it doesn't care.

I set the tray at an angle, just enough to slide,
just enough to keep the corners from clinking.

Clink once, the whole shop hears.

Clink twice, the story changes.

So I lock my breath to the work.

Inhale - cold metal.

Exhale - steady.

The vault door shows me a second face in the mirror panel,

one that wants to talk,

one that knows the price of talking.

I tuck the gold mask into the center,

then ring it with dull coins like armor made of everyday money.

No glitter, no spotlight - just weight where it can't be reached.

When I close the latch, I don't celebrate.

I listen to the seal hold.

I let my chest rise like a cursor stopping on a blank line.

Four seconds in.

Six seconds out.

The silver keeps reflecting, and I keep not flinching - because the next time the world comes for shine,

I'll already know how to hide it.



Separate Value From Time

Separate Value Time

How much you lose when you stare at the clock like it owes you?

Priyanka's phone vibrates - another "quick thing," another "just a sec,"

and her thumb keeps scrolling like scrollin' is work.

The deadline breathes down the screen's neck, no mercy in the pixels.

"Can you take this?" they ask, then add, "It's urgent, for real."

She hits send: the file attached, the edits stacked,

but wasted minutes crawl back in like they pay rent.

She counts it out on a timer app - Value-Per-Minute Model.

One minute: what it's worth.

Five minutes: what it costs her when she doesn't charge right.

She knows the trick: people don't respect time they can steal.

They keep talkin' while you're workin',

keep "checking in" like check-ins are currency.

Her cursor blinks - tap-tap - then she pauses.

"Priyanka, you there?"

She types, "Yep," then deletes it.

A "yep" is a free minute.

A free minute becomes a habit.

The clock won't stop - it keeps dragging seconds across her desk like sandpaper.

Tick. Tick. Tick.

She can feel the value slip where she didn't lock it in.

So she stands up, stretches her wrists, grabs the kettle,

and says, "I can do it after my rate window."

They laugh like it's a joke, like time is something you can borrow.

She watches the laughter fade when the invoice shows teeth.

A minute spent "thinking" costs more than a minute spent cutting.

A minute spent "waiting" costs more than a minute spent charging.

She doesn't negotiate with seconds.

She sprints through them.

Clock Teeth

The wall clock in her office sounds like chewing - not loud, just relentless, like a metronome with a grudge.

She's got her headphones on, but the tick still finds her brain.

It's 9:13 when the client starts "just one more thing."

9:14 they ask again.

9:15 she can feel her value thinning out like ink in water.

"Can you fix the intro?"

"Sure, but I need the word count and the deadline."

"Deadline is... whenever."

Whenever is how people pay you in air.

She opens her spreadsheet - minutes, minutes, minutes - then highlights the row marked "turnaround window."

Value-Per-Minute Model, bolded like a warning label.

She doesn't say "model" out loud.

She just charges like she means it.

The clock teeth click closer with every delay.

She tries to be nice - she really does - but niceness without a price tag becomes a donation box.

They keep dropping questions in like pennies,

then act surprised when the drawer stays empty.

At 9:19, she stops typing mid-sentence.

Her screen's glow looks like judgment.

She whispers, "You want speed, you pay for speed."

The client sends a voice note - fast talk, no structure.

She listens once, twice, then saves it for later.

Later is where the value goes to die.

So she schedules it, locks it,

and tells them: "That's a separate block. Same day, different price."

They go quiet.

Quiet is the sound of someone realizing time has a cost.

The clock keeps chewing anyway - tick, tick, tick - but now her minutes aren't loose.

Now they're strapped down.

She hates the hustle that pretends she's a machine,

so she becomes one on purpose:

one minute, one rate, no freebies.

Run the minutes clean,

or watch them run you.

Sprint Anyway

Her laptop says 00:00:58 on the timer,

but the client keeps typing like the timer is for someone else.

"Can you squeeze it in between calls?"

Between calls is a trap - it's where people dump their mess and call it urgency.

She hits play on a rough cut of the draft,

listens for the part where the sentence stumbles,

then marks the line with a red underline.

Not because she's angry - because anger is slower than accuracy.

She's worked too many "quick" jobs

to still believe "quick" means "cheap."

Quick means "they'll try."

Try means "they'll test your boundaries until you flinch."

The clock slides forward like a blade.

She can feel it in her shoulders.

Her jaw tightens when they say, "We just need a little tweak."

A little tweak becomes twenty minutes of rewriting.

Twenty minutes becomes a week she'll never get back.

So she sprints anyway - not running from work, running through the waste.

She turns on Focus Mode,

turns off the extra explanations,

puts her Value-Per-Minute Model on the table with silence.

She sends the revised section with timestamps:

"Updated during the paid block."

No big speech.

No apology.

Just receipts.

They reply, "Why so strict?"

Because strict is what keeps my rent paid.

Because strict is what keeps my time from getting sliced into crumbs.

Because strict is how you stop being an open door.

The clock keeps ticking like it's laughing.

She laughs back, but under her breath.

She's not letting the minutes belong to them.

Not even one.

She finishes the edit at 00:07:12 - then shuts the laptop like slamming a gate.

If they want more, they can buy more.

If they want her calm, they can earn it.

The sprint ends, but the boundary stays.

Open Tabs, Closed Time

Her browser is a landfill of tabs - drafts, notes, screenshots, "later" links.

The client asks, "Are you still on this?"

Still on it is a question that tries to steal another minute.

She drags the tab that doesn't matter into a folder called "Waiting."

Waiting is a shelf, not a promise.

She hates that people turn time into a toy - click, scroll, refresh, repeat - like value grows back if you poke it enough.

She clocks herself:

two minutes to read,

three minutes to mark,

five minutes to cut.

She doesn't do "vibes editing."

Vibes don't pay her.

Vibes don't buy groceries.

Vibes don't buy back the hour she lost yesterday.

The clock in the corner flips from 2:02 to 2:03.

Tick.

Her phone buzzes - new message.

She watches it buzz like a mosquito she refuses to chase.

"Can you hop on a call real quick?"

Real quick is the phrase that means "we'll keep you until you break."

She tells them, "Not quick. Booked."

Then she sends the revised excerpt with tracked changes.

They get mad because she didn't bend.

They get mad because the minutes didn't slide.

When they say, "It's taking forever,"

she thinks: you don't see the minutes that don't get wasted.

You see only the output, not the discipline.

The Value-Per-Minute Model sits in her head like a lock.

Every "quick" request is tested at the door.

If it isn't paid, it doesn't enter.

She closes the folder of waiting tabs,

keeps one open for proof,

then goes back to the work that actually moves the needle.

The clock keeps chewing.

She keeps feeding it only what's worth swallowing.

By 2:17, the draft is cleaner.

Not magically.

Surgically.

And the minutes she didn't waste

feel like a victory she can hold in her palm.

Rate Window

She sets a rate window like a fence line.

Not a suggestion.

A boundary with a number on it.

The clock hits 6:00 and the inbox tries to sprint ahead of her.

A message lands: "Need this by tonight."

Tonight is a fog word.

She wants a time, not a vibe.

She replies with one sentence:

"Send the files now, and I'll start in the next window."

They push back - "Can you just do it now? It'll take you five minutes."

Five minutes is always the lie.

Five minutes is never five minutes.

Five minutes is five minutes plus questions plus rework plus "actually..."

Five minutes becomes a hole you fall into

and suddenly you're working past midnight

for the same price you should've charged earlier.

The clock won't stop - it keeps turning like a wheel under pressure.

Her urge to sprint anyway hits hard,

like her body wants to be generous before her brain finishes math.

She feels that urge like muscle memory.

She wants to prove she can.

But proving gets you exploited.

Proving becomes a pattern.

So she opens her timer: 00:30:00 for the next block.

She starts the edit.

She cuts the weak lines.

She tightens the rhythm.

She doesn't chase the client's panic.

She catches her own discipline.

When the client asks again inside the window,

she answers once: "That's outside scope for this block."

Scope is the word that tells people where the value ends.

Tick. Tick. Tick.

The seconds pile up like receipts.

At 6:30, she stops.

Not because the work is done - because the window closed.

She can feel her value standing up straight again.

The urge to sprint back roars in her chest,

but she makes it sprint toward her next paid hour,

not toward freebies.

The clock keeps teeth.

She keeps rates.

She keeps moving with purpose, not with panic,

and time finally learns it can't drag her.

CHAPTER 22

Pay Bills Without Apology

“Bills don’t care how you feel - so I pay with my mouth shut and my hands loud.”

Late Notice Anthem

Front door got a paper like a bruise, thick and gray

Gabe said, “Read it out loud,” like the words got to bleed

Phone buzz - rent due, gas due, the little fees that breed

I got a bill-beat continuance in my ribs, thump-thump

Even when my throat wants to fold, I keep the metronome

Late fee call: “We can help you,” like a trap with manners

I said, “Help me by taking less,” and my voice stayed sharp

Electric got cut before, I learned that dark math

Now I keep the receipt stack like protection spells

\$68.41 left for groceries - still I don’t skip the light

I cry in the sink after I pay, water running so it don’t echo

Something to cry for, yeah - because the crying don't stop the due date

I fold that tear into the envelope and seal it clean

Gig money hits like confetti then disappears in one breath

Gas tank, app fees, insurance - every swipe a little tax

My card declines once, and my whole week turns into static

I still ride the bus to the kiosk, cash in my palm

ATM line talk: "You good?" I lie "I'm good"

Then I stare at the screen like it owes me an apology

The continuance is stubborn, it don't ask for forgiveness

It just beats: pay, pay, pay - then breathe for a second

If I'm gonna break, I break after the numbers are handled

Not before - never before

Golden Mask Interest

I count the numbers like a fistful of sand,

Then bite my tongue where the late charges land;

The notice says "final," I don't understand,

I only understand the meter's demand.

I swipe, it stings - my balance turns to ash,

But bills still knock, like neighbors with no class;

I wipe my face, the mascara in a splash,

And sign my name so the lights don't ask.

They want me begging, want me soft and small,

Want my pride to fold like paper at the door;

I keep my grip, I pay the hurt in full,

For crying later - when the shutoff's sure.

So I beat on, even when my throat is cracked,

Pay first, then let the grief get back.

Receipt Rain

Gabe tears the envelope

Rent due, red stamp, no pause

He folds it anyway

Kiosk Screen Glare

Card says "declined" once

He counts cash like a drum

Then breathes through the error

Split Payment Rhythm

Groceries wait outside

Light's on - his eyes stay open

He swallows that hurt

Bill-Beat Continuance

Heartbeat like a tap

Pay, pay, pay - no permission

Crying after dusk

Cut-Off Warning

Phone rings, threat in tone

He hangs up, pays the next

Silence still bills due

Paid With My Mouth Shut

"Pay it or get cut" - that's the script I live with,

A clock that laughs at "tomorrow" in its teeth;

I seen my hands shake, still I don't give.

I pay the hurt in full, I don't plead.

They send a bright red notice like a dare,

I hear it through the walls, through every room;

My throat wants to scream, but bills don't care.

I pay the hurt in full, I don't plead.

The landlord got a tone like a lock clicking,

Late fees grow like weeds when you miss a day;

I count gig miles, receipts I keep sticking.

I pay the hurt in full, I don't plead.

Electric wants its cut, the gas wants proof,

Phone wants its piece for the same damn talk;

My eyes get hot, I still don't lose the groove.

I pay the hurt in full, I don't plead.

I cry in the sink so the neighbors won't hear,

Snot on the countertop, shame in my smile;

Then I open the app and pay through the fear.

I pay the hurt in full, I don't plead.

So when the breakdown comes, I don't stop the payment,

Let it come after - like the song after drums;

I keep the bill-beat continuance, no replacement,

I pay the hurt in full, I don't plead.

I pay the hurt in full, I don't plead.

Be Kind Like a Weapon

Door-Click Kindness

The bus hissed at the curb, and my change hit the floor like it didn't trust me.

Amina said, "Hold it," and the driver looked annoyed - like kindness costs extra.

She knocked once on the metal pole, then again, softer, like a promise with hands.

A man in a work vest tried to rush past her, jaw set on hurry, but she just stood there - door held open by posture, not permission.

He finally stepped in, muttering, "My bad," like the word was new.

Amina didn't "explain." She didn't preach. She slid her Kindness-Impact Protocol into the moment: eye contact, one sentence, time made real - no drama, no receipt.

When the next person fumbled with the fare, she covered the gap with exactly three dollars, then let the silence stay clean.

Kindness as a deliberate strike - sharp enough to change the angle of someone's day.

Three Dollars, Again

Hold it.

Hold it when your phone is buzzing louder than your conscience.

Hold it when your shoes are already halfway out the door.

Hold it when the elevator's stuck and folks start swinging words like punches.

Hold it when you hear "I got it" and you can tell they don't.

Hold it when you see a kid clutch the wrong ticket like it's a life raft.

Hold it when the line behind you is impatient and your chest wants to snap.

Hold it when you're tired, but tired don't mean cruel.

Hold it when you can't fix everything, so you fix one hinge.

Hold it when you've got three dollars and no extra pride.

Hold it when somebody's hands shake and you don't laugh at the tremor.

Hold it until the door closes on the right person.

Hold it until your anger learns a new job.

Hold it until you feel it: kindness isn't soft, it's leverage.

Hold it - then walk like you meant it.

Hold it, because "later" is a liar with good marketing.

Hinged Words

DOOR

not a rumor

HOLD

it

like

you mean

OPEN

with

your whole

mouth

Not "sorry"

but

action

Amina lifts

the latch - click

Three dollars

to the floor - catch

No speech

just

switchbacks

of mercy

Let the next

person

pass

clean

Strike-Quiet

Amina leaned on the handle like it owed her an apology.

“Go ahead,” she said, but her eyes did the real work.

The man rushed in first, then froze - caught by the pause.

He wanted to be fast more than he wanted to be decent.

She didn't shame him.

She just kept the door from becoming a wall.

When the driver asked, “You got time?” she answered with her hands.

She tapped her card reader twice - proof without flex.

Somebody behind her dropped their coins, loud clatter.

Amina bent, picked them up, and didn't look away.

That's the Kindness-Impact Protocol:

one clear move,

one clean sentence,

then space for the other person to breathe and still arrive.

She'd learned the math from community meetings - impact is never abstract when you can measure the next step.

Later, she told the organizer who runs the block:

"Tomorrow's meetings don't help if we slam the door today."

So she struck the moment like a match - not to burn,

to light a path that was already there.

And when the bus lurched forward, nobody clowning her for being kind.

They just moved different.

Quiet, but different.

Protocol Mercy

Amina holds the door like it's a muscle - working, not begging.

The man steps in, and his face stops acting like it's mad.

Three dollars on the floor, caught before it becomes a lesson.

Kindness lands, sharp and specific, not a vague moral obsession.

She says one sentence, then lets the rest be action.

No lecture - just a hinge, turning the whole situation.

When the elevator hates you, she still makes room with her body.

Her calm is a weapon - aimed at the next person's doubt.

Hurry tries to run the block, but she slows the whole track.

Kindness hits like a strike, and the day can't strike back.

Write Listener to Good Man

Cracked Speaker Prayer

T heo, forty-one, choir director, walks in with a throat full of weather.

He taps the cracked phone speaker like it owes him rent.

"Listen," the practice track says - then fuzzes on "li - " and cuts.

He holds the mic steady anyway, like stubbornness is a metronome.

In his pocket: a church key, a notepad, and tape for the hinge.

He tells the bass section, "Don't talk over the count."

They grin, then they start laughing at the hiss.

Theo doesn't yell - he leans in so the room has to hear him.

The speaker pops again, and the words come back wrong, like a lie.

"Be kind," it tries to say, but the timing stutters.

Theo rewinds the same ten seconds three times.

No one claps. Everybody hears the mess.

He points at the silence like it's a note on the score.

"Good listener," he says, "you catch the skipped syllable."

The Listener-Led Ladder

Theo shows the ladder on a screen that won't stay bright.

The cracked speaker keeps biting the consonants.

He feeds it the verse, then waits for the room to catch up.

He counts breaths like coins - slow, no counterfeit.

"Say it back," he whispers to the echo in the hall.

The hall answers with static and sincerity.

He lifts his hand for the next line, not the next argument.

When a kid interrupts, Theo doesn't swing - he pauses.

The pause becomes a hook, the hook becomes a hook-up.

The speaker finally clears: "Good man."

Theo nods like he just watched the choir land in key.

He doesn't crown himself. He just listens harder.

Static Amen

First we hear the "li - "

Cracked speaker chews the consonant

I still catch the beat

Breath Catcher

Theo waits one more beat

Eyes on the mouth, not the ego

Let the count speak first

Key Turn

Church key, taped hinge

Phone pops back the softened line

Hear it whole, not loud

Stutter Oath

“Good man” comes in shards

He repeats the missing word

Until it fits my tongue

Ladder Rung

Listen down the hiss

Then climb out of your own noise

Let mercy be the meter

Tape Over Talk

Theo covers the mic crack with tape

So the room can hear the truth, not the blame

Don't Step On It

If you rush the line, you trip the count

If you cut the silence, you lose the sound

Theo's Ten Seconds

Ten seconds, same loop, no flex

The listener in me stays until the rest comes

Bass Section Lesson

Bass laughs - then stops mid-breath

Because he heard the crack and still kept time

Choir Key Currency

You can't trade loud for love

Not when the speaker's dying and the heart's trying

The Softened Cadence

I don't need a bigger mouth

I need your ear turned on, no static doubt

Rewind, Not Revenge

When they talk over me, I rewind

I catch the tone under the noise they hide

Good Man Echo

"Good man" hits the wall, half-broken

I answer it back gentle, so it lands unspoken

Rung of Real Listening

Theo's phone speaker is cracked like a cheap promise - every "s" turns into grit, every "t" turns into a stuttered threat.

He's got the choir warm, got the room hot with mouths, got his hands ready to conduct.

Then the track does it again: "Good man" tries to come through, but it falls apart mid-syllable.

A soprano starts to correct the timing out loud, like she's fixing the weather.

Theo doesn't swing his baton at her.

He lifts two fingers - hold - and lets the static sit between them like a test.

"Listen," he says, but the speaker only gives him: "Li - "

The kid snickers. The snicker is quick, the consequences are quicker.

Theo rewinds the exact ten seconds, not because he's stubborn - because he's precise.

He turns his face toward the sound, not toward the disrespect.

He makes the bass section breathe together on purpose, no jokes, no side quests.

When the hiss returns, he doesn't fight the hiss.

He catches the shape of the missing word with his ear first, like learning a song from a broken radio.

"Good - " the speaker coughs.

Theo nods like he heard the rest anyway.

"Good man," he mouths, soft, so the room has to lean in to catch it.

The snickers fade into effort.

A hand goes up, not to argue, but to signal: "I'm with you."

Theo taps the screen once - again - like he's knocking on the door of someone's attention.

The speaker pops, the volume droops, the cadence comes back calmer than before.

He conducts the softened line like it's a fragile glass ornament.

He doesn't reward the loud.

He rewards the ear that stays open when the world tries to interrupt.

When the choir finally lands in time, nobody talks over the last note.

They let it ring out, even with the crack still there.

Theo doesn't smile big - he just keeps listening, because that's the only way the "good man" survives the noise.

He covers the mic crack with tape again, not to hide it - just to keep the message clean enough to reach somebody.

And I swear, when the room learns that kind of listening, it starts acting like it can be a good man, too - step by step, rung by rung.



Turn Threat Into Boundary

Knife-Edge Toast

Why does my hand twitch like it got its own mouth?

The urge talks first - sharp, hungry, sure.

My palm wants to draw a line through somebody's face.

They cut me in line, I feel it:

a spark under the skin

like a lighter held too close to gas.

"Step back," I say.

My voice stays flat, but my teeth are loud.

My brain shows me two exits:

stab the sentence clean,

or slap the meaning out their mouth.

I picture the impact like a bartender counts change - one, two, stack it, make it neat,

then watch the mess get paid for.

Ruth, 37, keeps a towel on the bar

like it's a small flag for peace.

I hear the clink of glass like a countdown.

He grins, pushing my boundary with his whole body.

"Come on," he says, "you won't do shit."

My fist tightens anyway.

The knuckles write threats in invisible ink.

Then the Boundary-Not-Blade Switch flips - quiet, sudden.

Not a hero moment.

Just a switch in the muscle memory.

I open my hand like a receipt:

proof I chose restraint.

The next move is small and heavy.

I slide the coaster between us.

I set the glass down slower than his ego can keep up.

"Drink your side," I tell him.

No rage in it - just a wall made of routine.

He tries again.

His breath comes out hot, like he wants a fight to taste.

I feel the slap rising, thick as syrup.

I feel the stab rising, clean as a promise.

But I choose the third thing:

I turn my threat into a boundary sign.

I point to the door without touching it.

I don't swing.

I don't stab.

I don't let my body become the headline.

He steps back when he realizes I'm not playing.

My heart still thumps like a bass drum

under the floorboards of my ribs.

I still want to hurt something - just not the wrong target.

I wipe the counter like I'm erasing a crime scene.

I hand him his change like it's a verdict.

"Next time," I say, "keep your hands to yourself."

He mutters, but he leaves.

And the urge stays in me,

waiting for the next cheap trigger.

I don't feed it with violence.

I feed it with structure:

a towel, a coaster,

a measured breath,

a line he can't cross.

Grit Refrain

Hold it - don't swing - hold it, hold it

Your eyes want a bruise, my fist wants a lesson, hold it, hold it

The bottle's just a bottle, the rage is the real theft, hold it, hold it

He laughs like consequences are a joke on tap - hold it, hold it

I feel the stab in the air, clean and sudden, hold it, hold it

Ruth lifts the towel, cuts the moment's power, hold it, hold it

My mouth wants to curse, my body wants to correct - hold it, hold it

Even when my blood says "go," I don't - hold it, hold it

I sign the night with silence, not damage - Ruth, hold it, hold it

Coaster Fence

A coaster hits the counter - not hard,

just certain,

like a “no” you can’t misread.

His shoulder checks my space again.

I feel the slap in my wrist,

the stab in my imagination,

both of them dressed like solutions.

“Say it,” he dares.

He wants me to turn my boundaries into a weapon.

My breath goes shallow.

My jaw locks tight enough to crack a lie.

I see the aftermath in my head:

sirens, paperwork, the whole ugly machine

eating my name like a snack.

I’m not scared of jail.

I’m scared of becoming the kind of person

who only understands love through impact.

So I do the Boundary-Not-Blade Switch,

right there,

while the music still thumps

and the glass still shines.

I straighten the bar mat by exactly one inch.

I move the bottle label so it faces straight.

Order is my armor.

He stops pushing when he realizes

I'm not reacting like a cornered animal.

He tries a smile.

I keep my face neutral,

like a lock that doesn't have to explain itself.

My hand hovers - then opens.

Threat turns into distance.

"Step back," I say,

and I mean step back into your own life.

He swears under his breath.

I don't match his volume.

I lift my voice the way you lift a lid off a pot - careful,

so nobody gets burned by accident.

"Last drink," I tell him.

No warning speech.

Just a boundary with a timestamp.

He looks around, hunting for backup.

Nobody's got his back.

They're watching the way I hold still.

My urge keeps screaming in the dark:

stab, slap, prove you're dangerous.

I answer it with action that doesn't bruise.

I call his tab.

I set the receipt down

like a judge slapping the gavel without touching skin.

He grabs the drink and walks away,

angry at the fact that anger didn't win.

When the door shuts,

my body finally exhales.

The switch doesn't make me soft - it makes me precise.

I still feel the edge.

I just don't hand it the steering wheel.

Ruth wipes the bar again,

circles the same spot,

erasing the possibility

before it turns into a headline.

Towel Oath

The urge comes like a dare with teeth. My muscles want to cash it in - one swing, one hit, one clean correction. But the Boundary-Not-Blade Switch clicks in my bones: I keep the blade inside my mouth and the slap inside my nerves. I reach for the towel instead, grip it like a handle that only turns toward order. I reset the glass, measure the space, and speak the boundary without theatrics - short, flat, undeniable. He tests again, and I don't escalate; I narrow the outcome. "Not here." "Not like that." "You're done." The threat stays hungry, but it's blocked by routine - coaster, receipt, distance. When he finally backs up, I feel the violence retreat, not because it vanished, but because I refused to feed it.

Receipt Line

His hand keeps wandering

like it's searching for a weak spot.

My urge tightens - sharp, impatient.

I can almost taste the slap,

almost hear the thud it would make.

But I'm holding a Boundary-Not-Blade Switch in my head

like a hidden switchblade that's turned inward.

I slide the receipt between us.

Paper, not punch.

A thin line with thick consequence.

"Cash out," I say.

No screaming.

No invitation.

He scoffs,

like he thinks I'm bluffing with my calm.

I feel my pulse rise anyway.

The stab wants to be a headline.

The slap wants to be a trophy.

I breathe through it.

Slow enough to make the anger lose oxygen.

He steps closer - one more time.

I don't flinch.

I don't swing.

I don't reach.

I point to the exit and keep my hands busy:

wipe, stack, straighten, reset.

My restraint isn't "nice."

It's control.

It's me deciding that damage doesn't get paid on my shift.

He can hate me for the wall.

He can call it cold.

I call it survival with manners.

When he finally backs away,

my body still wants to celebrate the fight.

So I give it a different win:

I lock the door with my eyes on the latch,

not on his face.

I hear the urge grumble in my chest,

but it doesn't drive.

The boundary holds.

The night keeps moving.

And Ruth keeps the golden mask of restraint on tight,

until the next threat tries to cross the line,

until the urge comes back asking for a blade - and I switch it into a fence instead

CHAPTER 26

Feed the Mouth, Not the Hate

“Extra salami, not extra hate,” he said, like it was policy.
I’m at the counter, not praying, just waiting on heat.

The register clicks like a verdict with mozzarella breath.

He hands me the Italian sub, long as a grudge I can’t afford.

Extra salami - red coins, stacked like somebody’s bad decisions.

I bite, and the grease talks back first.

I taste pepper and regret in the same chew.

Then my phone buzzes - somebody online wanna start a war in caps.

I don’t feed that mouth.

I feed mine.

Not the one typing threats, not the one hungry for a headline.

The one that has to keep moving through the day.

My stomach’s got receipts.

My hands got work to do.

Don’t talk to me about “deserve” when I’m trying to survive.

The only thing I'm stacking is lunch and patience.

Chicken and egg biscuits in a paper bag, warm corners, no drama.

One biscuit tears, steam rising like a plan that actually pays rent.

Egg on the inside, chicken holding it down.

Like we already know: separate parts don't mean separate families.

Say "split," and I hear "freeze."

Say "cut," and I hear "cold shoulders."

Nah - keep the whole meal together.

I watched somebody try to separate love into pieces.

They called it "boundaries."

I called it starving with better vocabulary.

So I hold the bag like it's evidence.

Salami grease on my knuckles, biscuit crumb on my sleeve.

I'm not saving the world.

I'm saving the next bite from becoming a fight.

Keep that hate in the trash where it belongs.

Feed the mouth that has to get up tomorrow.

Let the rest choke on their own noise.

Extra Salami

"Don't add hate, add salami," the deli guy laughs, like he knows me.

The slicer sings - metal on metal - steady, mean, honest.

I point at the line on the menu like it's a contract.

Extra salami, extra heat, extra weight in the belly.

He asks, "You sure?"

I say, "Yeah," like certainty is a seasoning.

Because hate is light.

It floats up quick, then disappears when it's time to pay.

But salami stays.

It sits heavy on the tongue and makes quiet out of chaos.

Outside, somebody's yelling at a stranger for parking wrong.

Inside, the oven hum keeps my blood from boiling over.

I take the sub like a shield.

Not armor made for fighting - armor made for living.

And I don't argue with the guy who wants me angry on command.

I don't do the back-and-forth dance for free.

My balance sheet don't include rage.

Neither does my family.

Family - yeah, that word that people love to break.

They split it down the middle like a sandwich they don't have to eat.

They take the chicken out and act like the egg doesn't matter.

They swear it's "for the best," like best ever fed anybody.

Chicken and egg biscuits in my bag - proof that you can hold two things.

Protein and comfort.

Stubborn and soft.

Crunch and warmth.

I hate the way people talk like separation is growth.

Nah.

Separation is just hunger with a costume.

I saw a friend get iced out like he committed a crime for being loud.

But nobody asked if he ate.

Nobody checked the fridge.

So I learned: if you don't feed the mouth, you grow the hate.

You water it.

You let it root.

Then it takes over everything.

I'm not watering it.

I'm eating.

Chicken and Egg

The biscuit splits - clean crack, butter smell, no negotiation.

Chicken on one side, egg on the other, still together in the bite.

I chew slow, like I'm teaching my nerves how to calm down.

Someone's on my phone typing venom, thumbs drumming like a trap.

They want me to answer.

They want me to swing words like fists.

But my mouth is busy.

My mouth is working overtime to keep me from snapping.

Because when you're hungry, you don't think straight.

You just reach for the nearest fire.

They say "cut him off," like it's cardio.

They say "block and move," like grief is a browser tab.

I've seen what happens after the block.

Silence turns into rot.

Rot turns into rumors.

Rumors turn into violence with good grammar.

I'm not building a world like that.

I'm building a meal.

Chicken and egg biscuits - same bag, same heat, same promise.

No separating the parts just because people get mad.

The hate wants distance.

Distance makes it easier to pretend you don't know the outcome.

But I know outcomes.

I watched a classmate get kicked out of the kitchen schedule for "attitude."

They didn't ask why the hands shook.

They didn't ask if the fridge was empty.

They just stamped paperwork and called it "discipline."

Discipline don't fill stomachs.

Discipline don't hold a family together.

So I eat my biscuit and swallow the lesson.

Don't let anger be the only thing you can afford.

Feed the mouth that can still forgive.

Feed the mouth that can still work.

Feed the mouth that keeps showing up with crumbs on its sleeves.

And if somebody wants to throw hate like it's seasoning - let it fall to the floor.

I'm not serving it.

Not tonight.

Refusing to Split

Salami grease on the wrapper, my thumb leaving a red smear.

I wipe it off, like I'm cleaning evidence from a scene I didn't start.

The sub's long - too long to pretend I don't deserve it.

Extra salami, extra bite.

My friend wanted to "cool off" from their own people.

Said, "I'm done," like done is a cure.

They tried to separate the family into "safe" and "unsafe."

But safe don't mean fed.

Unsafe don't mean unloved.

It just means somebody forgot the basics.

Chicken and egg biscuits prove basics still slap.

Egg holds the stick.

Chicken holds the weight.

Together they don't fall apart when you hold them with shaking hands.

That's what I'm refusing: the split that masquerades as progress.

You can hate a behavior without starving a bond.

You can be mad without turning the kitchen into a courtroom.

I hear the hate-mouth crowd on the internet - always ready to chew somebody down to nothing.

They want you to trade your lunch for a comment section.

They want you to turn pain into performance.

But I'm not here to audition for their rage.

I'm here to keep my own life from tipping.

If I'm gonna be loud, I'll be loud with a full mouth.

I'll be loud with crunch.

I'll be loud with "extra salami" and "hold the family together."

Because when you separate, the leftovers rot.

When you rot, you get bitter.

When you get bitter, you start looking for somebody to blame.

That's how hate recruits.

That's how it grows.

So I don't feed it.

I feed the mouth that can handle tomorrow.

I feed the table that still has chairs.

I feed the people who show up even when they're tired.

I won't call it "enabling" when it's just eating.

I won't call it "weak" when it's keeping together.

You can keep your split.

I'm keeping the whole meal.

Table-First Bite

"Start with the table," my grandma voice in my head, even when she isn't here.

Not a speech - just a rule that hits like garlic on bread.

I set the paper bag down, and the room stops trying to turn me into a target.

Italian sub first - extra salami, no apologies, no hate.

Next, chicken and egg biscuits - crumbs like confetti for survival.

I don't stack them like enemies.

I stack them like family.

Because that's the Table-First Reversal in my bones.

Hate talks loud, but it can't hold a plate.

It can't carry groceries up stairs.

It can't sit at the table and chew without starting a fight.

It just spreads.

Like sauce on a shirt you didn't mean to stain.

I've seen people weaponize "boundaries" until nobody gets fed.

They say, "I need space," then act surprised when love starves.

They say, "We're done," then wonder why the house feels empty.

You can't build a future out of neglect.

Not when your hands still want something warm.

So I eat.

I let the salt hit my tongue and calm my temper.

I let the grease remind me: I'm not made of anger.

I'm made of appetite and choice.

If somebody wants to separate the family - I'll hand them a biscuit and watch their logic choke.

If they want to feed the mouth with hate - I'll shut the door on that hunger.

No extra salami for their nonsense.

No extra space for their cruelty.

I'm not splitting what still works.

I'm not cutting what still holds.

I'm not letting a grudge become the only flavor I know.

Feed the mouth that keeps you steady.

Feed the table that keeps you human.

And when the world comes asking for your anger like it's payment - you already know what comes next.

CHAPTER 27



Keep the Mask From Cracking

Antique Mask Shop

The bell above the antique mask shop don't ring - it coughs, like metal clearing a throat.

I slide my fingers under a curtain of dust

and grab the first mask that feels warm.

Gold foil flares on a crack I can't hide,

hairline seam like a warning label.

"Don't touch," the clerk says, deadpan,

but her eyes keep counting my breaths.

I whisper, "Keep it steady,"

like the glass might actually listen.

I try on the antique - it fits wrong at the jaw, then right at the fear.

In the mirror, my smile locks in place

like a zipper that won't come undone.

I hear my own voice behind the fabric,

muffled, mean, rehearsed.

The golden mask sits in a velvet case,

too bright for my hands to stay innocent.

I lift it - and the shop lights tilt, like they're jealous.

My reflection looks too clear to forgive,

every tooth a confession.

I set it down fast, like it could bite.

The seam stares back: keep the mask from cracking.

"Try it," the clerk says, finally human,

"but don't look too long - people start to see."

I swallow hard.

I grip the antique frame with both palms

and feel the fear turn mechanical.

Mask-Stability Technique, my secret muscle:

press the seam, breathe through the gap,

let the panic sit behind the gold like a locked door.

Golden Reveal

When velvet opens wide, the light spills gold,

A seam tightens up like teeth in locked restraint;

I lift the antique, feel my nerve grow bold,

Then drop it quick - too bright, too much, too faint.

The clerk says nothing; her eyes do all the talk,

Counting my breaths like bills that won't get paid;

I wear a smile that keeps my hands from chalk,

From writing what I am on every stair.

The mirror turns my face into a test,

Too clean, too sharp, no hiding in the glow;

I fear the moment people name the mess,

And crown it truth with nowhere left to go.

Keep the mask from cracking, keep it tight - I'd rather be unseen than seen too right.

Velvet Breath Cracks

Gold on my tongue, then metal in my teeth.

The antique clerk watches, not surprised - I press the seam, hold the panic.

Case Lid Shivers

Velvet case, breath fogging the glass.

A hairline flashes like a threat - don't stare too long.

Mirror Too Clear

My smile clicks shut, too crisp.

The golden reveal feels like a knife - my fear learns the shape.

Press and Pretend

I tighten the frame with both hands.

Mask-stability holds for one more minute - then my eyes blink truth.

Antique Bell Coughs

The bell coughs again, iron-rough.

I leave before they can read me - keep the seam asleep.

Keep the Mask Tight

I grip the antique, seam by seam, in place,

To keep the gold from splitting like a scar;

The clerk's eyes measure how long I can wear

A smile that won't admit it's out of grace.

I grip the antique, seam by seam, in place,

My breath runs slower than the bright display;

The mirror judges every little flaw - A face too clear can't stay in hiding space.

Keep the mask from cracking, keep it tight,

Or every light will turn to evidence;

Keep the mask from cracking, keep it tight,

'Til I can't tell which part of me is lying.

I grip the antique, seam by seam, in place,

The velvet case clicks shut like prison bars;

My hands remember panic in the dark - I grip the antique, seam by seam, in place.

Keep the mask from cracking, keep it tight,

Or somebody sees the fracture underneath,

Keep the mask from cracking, keep it tight,

So I can walk where they won't call me "truth."

I grip the antique, seam by seam, in place.

Gold Behind the Latch

The antique mask shop smells like old cologne and pennies.

The clerk slides me a new velvet cloth like it's a peace offering.

I don't ask for permission - I ask the seam to behave.

I tuck the golden mask back in its silver vault

with a thunk that sounds like a locked jaw.

Then I practice the Mask-Stability Technique

on the antique one I can actually stand wearing:

press the crack, breathe through the gap,

let my face stay trained even when my lungs don't.

"Are you coming back?" the clerk asks, low.

I say, "Not if you keep looking at me like that."

She laughs once - sharp, short.

Like she's heard my fear try on courage before.

I walk past the display glass and see my reflection flinch

before I even move.

My phone screen lights up - a notification I don't read,

because attention is a spotlight

and I'm scared of what it will prove.

I keep my eyes on the floor tiles,

counting the cracks like they're safe to count.

At the door, the bell coughs again, metal throat.

I leave without the gold on my face,

but the gold stays in my head - bright enough to find me later.

So I keep the antique on my skin in pieces:

the jawline steadied, the smile stitched,

the fear tucked behind the shine like contraband.

Because being seen too clearly

is just another kind of punishment,

and I'd rather sweat in the dark

than break open under somebody's stare.



Ask Who Am I

Golden Mouthpiece

I'm on a cracked mic, Daria 28, podcast light blinking like a guilty conscience, and the producer keeps yelling, "Hit the take - cut the silence."

I keep the golden mask on my face like a receipt I don't wanna show, and I say, "Don't ask who I am," like it's a lock code.

My throat does the refrain on beat - don't ask, don't ask - while the room waits to exhale.

The Late-Answer Refrain sits in my chest, slow-cooked: I answer after the mic dies, after the comments settle, after the room stops pretending it didn't hear me.

Don't Ask Me

Don't ask me when the air goes thin

Don't ask me why my jokes got teeth

Don't ask me what I'm hiding in that gold mask

Don't ask me who signed the bruises on my timeline

Don't ask me what I did with the keys at midnight

Don't ask me why my mouth stays quiet on purpose

Don't ask me what I mean by "I'm fine"

Don't ask me how I learned to dodge love like rent

Don't ask me who told me silence is a weapon

Don't ask me why my laugh comes late like a bus with bad brakes

Don't ask me why the notification bar feels like a threat

Don't ask me why "who am I" turns into a trapdoor

Don't ask me to explain the Late-Answer Refrain

Don't ask me to name the moment I snapped

Don't ask me to prove I'm real with receipts

Don't ask me to stay when the beat tells me leave

Don't ask me - let the answer show up late

Golden Delay

don't ask

don't ask

don't ask - - who am I

(hold)

don't ask

who am I

(late)

golden mask

silver vault

keep the key

out my mouth

don't ask

don't ask - - who am I

when the mic

stops catching breath

Wendy Cup Echo

The last thing the mic heard was "don't ask."

Then the line cut.

Not my voice - just the signal, like somebody yanked a plug from my ribs.

My headphones still buzz, static doing push-ups.

I see the episode timer climb, then freeze at 00:07

like it got scared of the question.

"Who am I?" sits in the comments like a dare.

I don't answer.

I let it rot in the feed.

I wash my brain with endorphins, still feel dirty.

I rehearse a lie so clean it shines

but the gold mask sweats truth around the edges.

Late-Answer Refrain - yeah, I heard you in the room.

It's not a promise, it's a schedule.

It's the way my mouth waits while my life speaks first.

When the silence lands heavy, I finally talk.

Not to be understood - to be acknowledged by the quiet I made.

Late-Answer Truth

Don't ask - my voice locks up like a phone on 1%

Who am I? - the answer comes after the upload, when nobody's watching

Don't ask - my mask stays golden, my eyes stay sharp

Who am I? - I'm the "no" you didn't hear until the beat died

Don't ask - your question turns to static in my teeth

Who am I? - I'm the part that speaks late, after you assume nothing

Don't ask - silence is where I keep the heat

Who am I? - me, arriving late like truth with receipts

CHAPTER 29

Name NoEmotion Without Denial

What does “fine” mean when your mouth’s a muzzle?

Miles: thirty, hospice shifts, keys on his ring clinking like a lie.

He hears it in the hallway - people breathing through their denial.

NoEmotion on my tongue like a pill you never swallow,

yeeeeaaaaahhhhh - like a chant that keeps the truth from knocking.

Golden Breath

Mask in the mirror - yeeeeaaaaahhhhh tastes numb,

truth bruises back.

NoEmotion hums low - I can’t feel the goodbye,

the goodbye feels loud.

Palm to chest, I lie - breath says I’m still here,

bones say “stop.”

Name on the tongue - NoEmotion, no tear,

then the tear arrives.

Stitched-up silence - yeeeeaaaaahhhhh holds the door,

truth walks in anyway.

Glass Tongue

Miles bites the word "fine" till it breaks.

NoEmotion laughs, then my jaw aches.

Yeaaaahhhhh - like a lock clicking shut.

Truth slips through the keys I never had.

They ask "you okay?" I let it pass.

My chest answers in static, not in cash.

I swallow the chant, keep my face clean.

Then the grief shows up with receipts and a mean grin.

NoEmotion sits where the heart should be.

Yeaaaahhhhh - like CPR for the lie.

I sign my name without meaning it.

Truth underlines everything I won't say.

Hospice Keys

Hospital hallway hum - yeeeeaaaaahhhhh, no words,
just pressure.

Miles checks the lock twice - NoEmotion says “don’t flinch,”
truth counts heartbeats.

Gloved hand on wrist - pulse stutters, then steadies,
like it’s choosing.

NoEmotion on my breath - yeeeeaaaaahhhhh, I swallow it,
truth spits blood.

Keys jingle again - I hear the “later” crumble,
and still stand.

Numbness-to-Name Bridge

I say NoEmotion to keep the room from burning.

Then truth climbs my throat like it learned my address.

Yeaaaahhhhh - my mouth plays dead on cue.

My eyes won’t rehearse; they testify without me.

I won’t call it pain, I’ll call it weather.

The weather changes anyway - sharp wind, no mercy.

NoEmotion is a mask with a pulse underneath.

I feel it twitch every time I pretend I'm tough.

Miles hears "goodnight" get heavier each time.

So I chant yeeeeaaaaahhhhh like it can't get real.

I try to name nothing, but it names me back.

NoEmotion, then the truth - both wearing my face.

I keep the chant like a bandage on a leak.

Truth still floods in, slow, relentless, mean.

Numbness Holds

Miles turns the key - click, click - like repetition can fix a bruise.

I hear the latch in my chest, tighter than any door.

They ask me how I'm doing, and my mouth says "fine"

like fine is a number you can dial.

NoEmotion sits on my tongue, quiet, heavy, practiced.

yeeeeaaaaahhhhh - loud enough to drown the part that shakes.

I clap the chant over the cracks.

I don't want the room to see me flinch.

I don't want the truth to catch me mid-breath.

A wrist in my glove: paper-thin, warm for now.

I count what I can count, because counting feels like control.

NoEmotion whispers, "don't name it, don't make it real."

So I don't - at least not out loud.

I say the day is manageable.

I say the night is just night.

I say nothing has to mean something.

Then the silence answers back in a different language.

It's not dramatic - just exact.

A body telling the truth with no poetry.

I feel my own numbness like a second pulse.

It keeps time with the lie, steady as a metronome.

yeeeeaaaaahhhhh - again, again - like repetition is armor.

But armor still weighs.

I try the Numbness-to-Name Bridge in my head - first bridge plank: "I'm okay."

Second plank: "I can handle it."

Third plank: "I'm not scared."

The wood snaps every time I step on it.

Because truth don't ask permission.

It climbs up through the chant, through the mask, through my throat.

I hear myself finally say a word I avoided all shift:

loss.

Not a vibe. Not a mood.

A blunt thing with teeth.

And NoEmotion - my clever little shield - spills out of my mouth

like it was never mine to keep.

yeeeeaaaaahhhhh turns into a question I can't dodge.

If I name it, does it hurt more?

Or does it hurt less because it's finally real?

Miles keeps the keys anyway.

I keep the voice anyway.

NoEmotion falls off the face like paint under heat,

and the truth stays standing, still breathing,

still demanding I don't pretend it's gone - yeeeeaaaaahhhhh - then the name, then the honesty, then the next breath.

CHAPTER 30

Build a Graveyard Shift



“Clock out, don’t clock out”

The EMT radio clicks like teeth on a dime.

“Two calls,” it says, then stutters.

The graveyard gate swings on a chain link prayer.

I’m on shift with Celeste, 33, badge cold against her wrist.

Shoes squeak where the gravel never heals.

The clipboard sweats in my hand.

They taught me “be kind,” like a rulebook.

But kindness don’t stop the stretcher from shaking.

Kindness don’t pay the landlord’s late fee.

I sign in “good behavior,” ink still sharp.

Then I see the sheet on the gurney, white like an apology.

The sheet says nothing, but it makes noise anyway.

“Did he make it?” someone asks through a cracked laugh.

I say, “I’m here,” like that’s a diagnosis.

My knuckles taste like pennies from the gloves.

At 2:17 a.m., the cemetery lights blink in sequence.

Not mercy - maintenance.

The dead don't need the Wi-Fi, but the living do.

A man in a hoodie tells me, "It's fine, it's fine."

His eyes do CPR on a lie.

I can hear the compression, even when he's silent.

The transport truck idles like a hungry animal.

I feel my own heartbeat trying to clock out early.

The night won't let it.

Graveyard Shift Etiquette

Bring the silence, don't bring the truth **INTO** *night*

I asked for breath, they handed me "he's resting" **INTO** *night*

Don't call it closure, call it paperwork **INTO** *night*

I watched the pulse fall off the monitor, slow **INTO** *night*

I kept the report clean, then smeared my hands **INTO** *night*

My "good behavior" badge shined like bait **INTO** *night*

At 3:03, my coffee went cold again **INTO** *night*

At 3:04, they said “try again” like it’s math **INTO** *night*

I’m Celeste, I did my best, they still wanted more **INTO** *night*

Monitor Beeps

The monitor keeps time like it’s collecting rent.

Beep... beep... beep - then a gap that feels like a door slammed.

They say, “Keep it together.”

My throat folds like a paper mask.

At the gate, the chain rattles - metal gossip.

Somebody’s praying with their mouth full of fear.

A family member wants the happy lie first.

“God needed him,” they say, like God got a shift schedule.

Like God clocked in late and forgot the rest of us.

I’ve got a tourniquet in the bag, a cold compress, a pulse oximeter.

I’ve got numbers that don’t care about comfort.

SpO2 doesn’t do condolences.

The EMT radio spits static like it’s chewing bones.

"Next call," it says, like the dead are queueing up.

Like the graveyard is a waiting room.

I sign "released" on good behavior forms.

Released.

That word tastes like permission.

Then I hear my own thoughts trespass.

Why do I feel guilty for surviving?

Why does truth feel like a weapon in my pocket?

A kid asks, "Will he wake up?"

I hear the question ricochet off the stone.

The kid's hopeful like a match held to gasoline.

I want to tell them the sad math:

sometimes the body quits before the story does.

But I watch myself swallow the sentence.

Because kindness is paperwork too.

Because hope is a bandage people want you to use.

Because the night demands a performance.

And I'm tired of acting.

Not tired of saving - tired of dressing the wound for company.

Good Behavior

Celeste's badge flashes under the ambulance lights, and the badge looks guilty even when it's trying to behave. I write "stable" with a pen that feels too small for the size of what I saw. The supervisor wants clean sentences, neat time stamps, a release that sounds like mercy instead of surrender. Outside the gate, the graveyard rows line up like judgment - every headstone a silent signature, every shovel a metronome for what we can't undo.

Then the radio coughs again, and the next call comes like a debt collector with a lullaby voice. I keep my hands steady, I keep my tone soft, I keep the story from cracking in front of people who can't afford the truth. But the truth is heavy. The truth sits in my throat like a stone that learned how to breathe.

Paper Coffins

At 4:12, the cemetery air smells like wet dirt and cheap cologne.

A man says, "He's in a better place," like he paid for it.

I nod.

Nodding is a skill they didn't train me for, but I got it anyway.

My partner asks, "Did you tell them?"

I say, "I told them what they could carry."

The sentence sounds gentle - sharp edges wrapped in fabric.

In the bag, the trauma shears stay clipped.

In my chest, the same shears want to cut the lie open.

Good behavior forms fold into my pocket.

Like paper coffins.

Like promises that rot slower than bodies.

A monitor stills, then restarts in my memory.

Beep - pause - beep.

The rhythm of almost.

They want sad truth to come with a smile,

like a funeral can be scheduled around comfort.

But my tongue remembers the gap where breath should've been.

I watch the family grieve in chapters they can stand.

I watch them turn the page fast when the words get too real.

I don't blame them.

I just hate the part where I help.

I hate the part where I become the editor of endings.

I hate the part where the night rewards me for staying quiet.

Celeste clocks out on time, because time is the only god with receipts.

And the graveyard keeps its job:

to swallow the truth, then hand back a nicer story so we can come back tomorrow.

CHAPTER 31

Stop Breathing as a Metaphor

Ramon hits record, then stares at the blinking cursor
“Don’t die on the draft,” he says through clenched teeth

He’s got a cheap mic, a cracked phone, and a deadline

The room smells like warm plastic and cold coffee

If he can’t create every day

then stop breathing - like the lungs got a switch

like the chest is just another edit that never loads

He tries to write anyway, hand shaking

The sentence comes out crooked, like a streetlight with one bulb

“Okay,” he mutters, “fine - so we make it ugly first”

He opens the notes app and names the file: DAY 31 TAKE 1

He doesn’t wait for the mood to clock in

He drags the scene forward by the collar

A train of bad ideas rolls through his head

He steps over it like a puddle with shoes on

He records a screen clip of nothing special

Then he talks over it like it's evidence

He keeps going - because stopping feels like a funeral

and he's tired of rehearsing grief

He counts breaths like metronome beats

Four in, four out, then one line drafted

then another

then another

like the body remembers the job

He pauses, wipes his palm on his jeans

and says, "I'm not waiting to feel alive"

He hits save

and the cursor stops mocking him

for now

Day 31 Take 1

Ramon's phone timer screams 00:30

He still hasn't found the "perfect" shot

He points the lens at the ceiling fan wobbling

and lets the blur be the beat

His mouth tastes like pennies

from biting words before they land

He says, "If I can't create every day

then stop breathing - no cap"

The thought shows up like a landlord

collecting unpaid oxygen

He wants to quit mid-sentence

wants the world to erase him on a schedule

So he pivots

not into peace, into production

He chooses anyway

a choice that looks dumb on paper

but pays rent in motion

He films his hands on the edit screen

dragging clips around like shuffling cards

He cuts out one mistake on purpose

leaves the noise in the corner

because the noise sounds honest

He makes a rule: use what's already charged

his battery hits 47% - he treats it like a fuse

He writes a voiceover: "I'm not praying for output

I'm building output"

Then he records the voice again

slightly faster

slightly meaner

like anger's a generator

He saves versions like receipts

TAKE 1, TAKE 2, TAKE 3

because quitting always tries to pretend it's final

When the timer dies, he doesn't collapse

he exports the file even if it's ugly

even if the compression makes everything look bruised

He watches it loop once

then twice

then he smiles like a thief caught his own heart

and decided to steal it back

Choice Furnace

Ramon sets a frying pan on the stove - no food

just the sizzle as a metronome

The sound is raw, metallic, impatient

like his thoughts refusing to line up politely

He can't breathe through the blank page

so he turns the blank page into a stage

He opens a new project named: CHOOSE

because "Create" feels like a god that never answers

He drops the pan mic close

records 12 minutes of hiss and crackle

numbers don't lie when the mind tries to vanish

If he can't create every day

then stop breathing becomes a threat

but threats don't get to drive

He sets a timer for 10 takes

ten attempts to make noise into rhythm

Take one: hiss only

Take two: hiss with breathing like a drumline

He laughs, short and sharp

"Yeah, I said it - breathe for work"

He overlays a shaky bass line from some free app

keeps it simple

keeps it from asking permission

Then he writes the caption like a punch

"Stop waiting. Hit export."

He doesn't even fix the grammar

because the grammar's not the story

the stubbornness is

He drags the audio under the video

and cuts the silence that tries to swallow him

When his chest starts to tighten, he talks back

"Not today. Not today. Not today."

He saves again

SHIFT+CTRL+S like a spell

like pressing it hard enough can hold the universe together

He watches the pan hiss turn into a hook

and his lungs remember they're not a judge

they're a tool

The Pivot Map

Ramon draws a map on printer paper - no street names

just lanes for what he can do when he can't do anything

Lane one: shoot something for 30 seconds

Lane two: talk for 30 seconds

Lane three: cut for 30 seconds

He's done with "someday"

it's a liar with clean shoes

He starts with the chair

the same chair every time

because repetition builds proof

He sits, stands, sits again

and records it like it's choreography

He says, "If I can't create every day

I'll stop breathing - cool

but I'm choosing the pivot before the panic wins"

He records his voice on a note app

then drops it into the edit

like dumping gasoline on a problem he's ready to light

He scrapes together B-roll from the same block

door handle, mailbox, passing sneakers

the world gives him scraps; he refuses to call them trash

He chooses the pivot when the edit starts to fight back

he doesn't restart the whole thing

he changes the angle

A new cut every time the panic tries to freeze him

he calls it "moving the blade"

He adds a title card that says nothing poetic

just the date and one blunt line: DAY 31

His hands sweat

his eyes sting from staring at the screen too long

Then he exports at 1080p

because he wants it to look like he meant it

The file lands on his folder like a weight

he carries it to the share button

He doesn't ask if it's good

he asks if it exists

It exists

so he breathes again

not because life got kinder

because he didn't give up the work

Oxygen Proof

Ramon's earbuds die halfway through the take

no sound in his ear, only the room

only the thud of his own impatience

He wants to quit like it's a reflex

like the body learned surrender before it learned rhythm

But he remembers the rule

if he can't create every day

then stop breathing

He hates that thought

so he uses it like a match against the dark

He opens the camera and points it at his face

then he stops looking for "pretty"

looks for “true”

He speaks without a script

two minutes of messy honesty

then he trims it down to 37 seconds

He chooses the pivot again

not “fixing himself”

just making a smaller, survivable thing

He uploads the clip to his folder

he labels it: OXYGEN PROOF

When the upload bar crawls, he clenches his jaw

and drags his thumb across the timeline

cutting out the parts where he sounds like he’s disappearing

He adds a single sound effect

a click

a reset

a little mechanical reminder that he’s still here

He watches the clip back on mute first

then with volume

then he nods like a judge who finally gets it

His chest loosens a notch

not healed, not clean - just loosened

He breathes like it's part of the craft

like oxygen is another ingredient

like the work needs it to hit

He doesn't stop breathing anymore

he redirects it

into edits

into exports

into the next ugly, necessary attempt

He closes the laptop

and the silence doesn't scare him - it waits for the next take

CHAPTER 32



Time Shift the Mind

Timer on the Microwave

Zara pressed “30:00” with a knuckle that shook,
the class bell already in her ear,

her phone buzzing like a trapped hornet - time shift won’t let my mind shift,

it keeps snapping back to the same loop,

like a tape that hates the rewind button.

She watched the kitchen timer tick through seconds

while her substitute folder sat open - blank lesson pages staring back,

“Thirty minutes,” she muttered,

then swallowed the word “sorry”

before it could turn into a stain.

The microwave door hummed shut.

Inside, a burrito sweated in foil,

outside, her thoughts tried to sprint in place.

She tried to change one thing:

counted every breath like quarters,

then counted the receipts in her purse - \$4.73 for gas,

\$2.50 for parking she didn't ask for,

a \$20 bus pass that still felt like a dare.

Time shift won't let my mind shift - so she shifted micro, not big:

one sip of cold water, one slow blink,

then she tore the foil clean,

gave the burrito a fair chance,

like respect was a tool you actually use.

Her phone screen flashed "Unknown" again.

No answer. No argument.

Just the timer, just the heat, just the moment.

When it beeped, she didn't celebrate - she packed the extra napkins,

left the classroom mess somebody else would inherit.

Small worth hit her like a receipt stamped paid:

a considerate gift, not loud - a sticky note that said "take your time, I got you,"

and the mind, still stuck,

started to loosen its grip

one microstep at a time.

Counterweight Moment

Time shift won't let my mind shift, still I try,

the timer clicks like knuckles on a door;

my thoughts run laps inside the same tight sky,

while foil warms up what I could not ignore.

I write a note in pen that won't lie through,

"Extra help tomorrow - no shame, no rush,"

then fold it small, like mercy made to fit the shoe,

and watch my anger lose its paper hush.

A breath. A blink. A cup of water, cold.

I count the seconds like they owe me change;

my worry wants a fight, but I stay bold,

and learn the weight of kindness as a range.

Not every shift is time - some are the hands

that hold the door, even when they're tired, understand.

Burrito Steam Pivot

Microwave timer

counts down, burrito steams - thoughts still on loop

Sticky note corner

"Take your time" in pen ink - mind loosens a notch

Receipt in her palm

gas money, parking sting - still she doesn't fold

Classroom trash bag

her hands do one clean thing - time shifts micro

Door Held Open

Time shift won't let my mind shift, still I try,

with foil sweating shut and seconds on my tongue;

the bell keeps lying, saying it's almost done,

time shift won't let my mind shift, still I try.

I write "tomorrow - no rush" in cheap blue ink,
and hand it like a lighter in the dark;
my thoughts are wild dogs, pacing, leaving marks,
time shift won't let my mind shift, still I try.
I press "start" again, not to escape the day,
but to prove a small worth can still hit hard;
a considerate gift - two napkins in the yard,
time shift won't let my mind shift, still I try.
So when the hallway claps and somebody slips,
I hold the door - no speech, just steady hands;
my chest still tight, but kindness understands:
time shift won't let my mind shift, still I try.

Microstep Gift

Zara stood by the doorway with her substitute badge crooked,
bag of markers in one hand, receipt in the other,
and her brain still yelling at the same old volume.
"Why you gotta feel like you're behind?" she asked herself,
but the question didn't answer - it just got louder, like a bully with homework.

So she did it smaller.

The Mind-Shift Microstep:

one breath that didn't bargain,

one blink that didn't apologize,

one step forward before her fear could trip her.

A kid dropped their pencil case.

Before her mouth could form a lecture,

she bent down and handed it back like it mattered - because it did.

Because the world already throws weight around

like it's free.

Later, she left a considerate gift on the teacher's desk:

a spare eraser, two pens that still wrote smooth,

and a sticky note that smelled like fresh glue.

"Use this when you're tired," it said,

no "sorry," no "I failed,"

just practical care, the kind you can touch.

Time shift wouldn't let her mind shift clean - it kept snagging on the same loop,

kept playing the same rewind in her skull.

But her feet learned a different beat.

Her hands learned a different job.

Her mouth stayed quiet where it wanted to bite.

That's when the microstep added up - not magic, not movie edits,

just proof that small worth can stack like bricks.

Next bell, she held the door again.

Next day, she brought extra napkins.

Next hour, she didn't burn the whole room down.

Time shift won't let my mind shift - so I shift micro until it has to follow.



Direct Your Life Like Film

Clapperboard Direction

You ever feel your life cut off mid-take, like the reel got yanked and nobody said “cut”?

I got Harold in my head, forty-five, theater tech, knuckles black with gaff tape residue, counting focus like it’s money. He grabs the clapperboard - *CLAP!* - and speaks to the next line like it owes him rent, like blocking is a weapon with a hinge. When his cue light blinks, he doesn’t beg the universe for timing; he plants his feet exactly where the mark tape says, then he swings the scene forward one step at a time. Need a director? He becomes one with his own hands: left wing, right wing, “hold,” “go,” breath measured to the next beat - because if you don’t direct your body, somebody else edits you.

Clapper Repeat

Who needs a director when you can direct the moment?

Who needs a director when your feet know the mark tape?

Who needs a director when the clapper hits and time obeys?

Who needs a director when you say “hold” and your anger stays put?

Who needs a director when you block the argument before it shoots?

Who needs a director when you count the beat like a stagehand counts lights?

Who needs a director when you stand left of the tape, not inside your chaos?

Who needs a director when you call "action" on the part that pays?

Who needs a director when you call "cut" on the part that don't?

Who needs a director when you swing your next sentence like a cue rope?

Who needs a director when you measure distance - exactly 3 feet, no guessing?

Who needs a director when you pivot on the same heel every time?

Who needs a director when you stop improvising with your life?

Who needs a director when you rehearse the apology like it's a monologue?

Who needs a director when you trap the bad thought behind stage curtains?

Who needs a director when the clapper says *CLAP* and your pulse syncs?

Cue Mark Map

[1] 3ft line

gaff tape bite

toe on the X

breathe

[2] whisper

“hold the beat”

no rush

no flinch

[3] CLAP

light cue blink

head nod

go

right wing - take the sentence

out the doorway

don't slam it

[4] CUT

swallow the impulse

reset the stance

same angle, new shot

Harold's Blocking

The clapperboard snaps like a judge's gavel - *CLAP* - and my thoughts stop acting wild.

Harold's got 3 feet of gaff tape on the floor, a hard boundary for soft chaos.

He doesn't "feel inspired."

He hits the mark.

He counts the breath that belongs to the next beat.

"Hold."

Not a prayer - an instruction.

A cue light blinks once, then again, like it's keeping score.

His shoe slides back to center.

His shoulders square to the audience he can't control.

I watch him rehearse the same walk like it's a spell that refuses to fail.

Left foot, pause.

Right foot, turn.

Don't let the sentence stumble into the wrong room.

When he says "action," it's not hype - it's direction.

When he says "cut," it's mercy with teeth.

He blocks the argument before it becomes a scene that ruins the whole run.

He blocks the silence before it rots into a different kind of loud.

Need a director?

Fine - be the one with the tape gun and the call sheet in your mouth.

If your life keeps missing its cue, don't blame fate.

Move your body like the take depends on it.

Because it does.

Action Cut

“CLAP” and the next line lands.

“CUT” and the old one can’t.

Mark the floor with 3 feet of truth.

Step where the tape says - don’t improvise bruises.

Hold the breath until the cue light agrees.

Then move like you rehearsed the exit already.

If you don’t direct it, something else edits you.

So block your sentence before it turns on you.

Keep the stance, change the shot.

Let the clapper teach your timing - then let it go.

CHAPTER 34

Treat Life as Battles Shifts

Battleshift Accounting

“Winning is just bookkeeping with bruises.”
“Every shift in the body counts as a move.”

Saltwater Ledger

Bruised ribs, inhale

sprint-thought hits the chest - pause, then swing again

Shoulders turn to drums

calves tighten like a knot - I count that as points

Skin says, “Stop.” I don’t

lungs trade air for speed - my pulse writes receipts

Coach yells “Again!”

but my wrist tape peels off - shift, not surrender

Backstroke, cold water

hands slap rank mistakes - I cash the backlash

Greed Without Romance

I keep score on purpose, not to be nice.

I want the win, then I want the prize.

My body's a battlefield, I don't negotiate.

I take the stance and I swallow the hate.

If my mask is gold, I lock it tight.

I don't share it - bragging costs light.

You call it selfish, I call it range.

I don't apologize for the damage I name.

My phone buzz like a threat, not a friend.

I turn it face-down, let the craving end.

I sharpen my excuses like lane lines.

You can't swim my race on borrowed time.

I lie with my smile, then I count the cost.

I don't romanticize why I lost - I admit it plain: I want what I want.

Battleship Accounting keeps me front to front.

Tape Marks Fate

Lactic heat rises

thighs burn like taunting math - I breathe through the red

Chin tucked, jaw clenched hard

water drags my ego down - I surface meaner

Coach whistles sharp

sodium stings the open cuts - I log the sting as proof

Tap the wall, turn

wrists snap, hips follow through - I call it clean

Mouthguard tastes like

cheap metal and bad decisions - I keep the receipt

Mouth Full of Receipts

You want mercy? Pay me in effort first.

I'm not a charity, I'm a hurt turned burst.

My selfishness got rules and a stopwatch.

If you slow my stroke, I cut the block.

I don't need "love," I need traction.

I need the lane, the clock, the reaction.

My calves shake - so what? I still push.

My fear can watch me miss, then get shook.

I talk slick, but my ledger's honest.

I want the win, I want it colossal.

I stash my gold mask behind silver locks.

Let the world guess - then watch me walk.

If my chest goes tight, I don't pray.

I shift my body and take the day.

Speed Mercy

Tap - tap - tape on my wrist, like a judge that won't blink.

I feel the pull before the pain arrives, that's my first warning.

The lane is a contract.

The wall is a receipt.

I break nothing soft - only what needs breaking.

My muscles shift like gears in a fight - hips snap, shoulders roll, ribs cage down, then open up.

That's Battleshift Accounting: every change in my body gets a number.

When my throat burns, I don't call it heartbreak.

I call it heat I can convert.

When my legs stutter, I don't call it destiny.

I call it a deficit I can correct.

"Again," the whistle cuts.

I hear it like debt collecting.

I roll my eyes, swallow my attitude, and chase the split time.

I admit it - selfish comes easy when the water's cold.

I want my lane clear.

I want my breath clean.

I want my scoreboard to glow while everybody else learns patience.

I'm Tessa, twenty-seven, competitive swimmer - but the name is just ink on a form.

What matters is the body:

how it tightens, how it loosens, how it tries to quit, how it gets dragged back.

My gold mask stays hidden, not because I'm humble - because I'm guarding what I earned.

If you reach for it, you're reaching for my leverage.

I don't do romance with the bruises.

I don't kiss the pain and call it fate.

I log it.

I adjust.

I strike the next shift before doubt can catch up.

If you want kindness, bring it like a towel - useful, not sentimental.

If you want me gentle, you're in the wrong lane.

I'm here to win, then win again, with receipts in my mouth.

Time keeps moving like a starter gun with no mercy.

So I move with it - counting every body-shift, cashing every backlash,

until the only love left is the hunger that won't stop.

CHAPTER 35

End the Rainbow With Rot

Nickel Rainbow

The rainbow's taped to the alley like a cheap poster

Imani tears it down with her thumbnail, fast

Color still clings - hot spray-paint shine

Then the sun hits it and the shine starts to flake

"Don't look at it like it's holy," she says

Her camera strap bites her neck, steady weight

She aims at the puddle where the colors bleed out

Red turns to rust, violet turns to bruise

She shakes the roll of tape off her fingers

The adhesive smells like pennies and old regret

She folds the rainbow back into itself

A collapsed promise, stacked and ready

At the curb, she sets a paper bag open - wide mouth

Inside: the end of the rainbow, but not for wishing

She scrapes the slick pigment with a key
It comes up gritty, like rot with a glitter suit
"Take the shine," she mutters, "leave the lie"
The bag sweats in her hand, warm rot-breath
She counts streetlights - seven, then eight - like the world only listens in numbers
A guy laughs: "You bagging treasure?"
She clicks one photo, flash snapping hard
"Treasure rots too," she answers, no pause
"Just slower when you pretend it won't"
She walks with the camera, not the craving
Her lens catches the tape residue on her knuckles
Color keeps trying to look alive
She stomps that part out, heel down, no mercy
When the rainbow's gone, the air feels meaner
Still, her eyes don't chase the color trail
She wipes the lens with a clean corner of her shirt
And the rot stays in the bag - contained, honest

Rainbow Ash

I watched the end of the rainbow sweat on tape, then turn to tar - ash, ash

I held it up for one last shot, the color stung my eyes - ash, ash

The shine ran off like lies when heat shows up, no prayer - ash, ash

I fed the glitter to a paper bag, let it rot in silence - ash, ash

Imani's lens stayed sharp while the myth went dull and broke - ash, ash

Rot Bag Lesson

Neon signs flicker like they're nervous

But the rainbow taped to the alley is braver - for one minute

then it collapses into the world's real texture

Imani snaps a photo of the drip

The flash makes the pigment look expensive

Like it could buy her rent with sparkle

Like it could pay off the overdue phone bill

Then she turns the bag in her palm

It's heavier than it should be

A sweet smell hiding something sour

Like candy left in a pocket with keys

"End of the rainbow," she says, voice flat

Not a wish - an ingredient

She scrapes it with a dime, collects what's left

No ceremony, just inventory

A dude tries to grab the bag

She pulls back, wrist firm, camera still swinging

He asks, "Why you doing that?"

She answers with a shrug that cuts

"Because shine lies," she says

"Because everybody wants the glow, not the cost"

She ties the bag shut with twine she found in her gear

Counts the knots like a beat she trusts

One knot for the flash

One for the laugh that sounded broke

She wipes her lens again, slower this time

Not to make it clean - to make it honest

to stop seeing what she wants instead of what's there

Later, when the tape residue dries on her fingers

it looks like rust map lines

routes back to bad decisions

routes that still lead to the same hunger

She walks anyway, but she walks different

No chasing light that disappears on contact

No bargaining with color that won't last

She leaves the alley with a rot in the bag

and a lesson in her teeth - don't worship what rots on schedule

don't call it fate when it's just decay

Tape Gospel

Imani tears the rainbow down like it's evidence. The last shine won't hold - sunlight scrapes it off the way reality scrapes off excuses. She folds the strips into a paper bag and seals it tight, like she's locking away a bad habit that keeps trying to dress itself up. The pigment stains her knuckles; it's slippery at first, then suddenly gritty, like truth after the party ends. She clicks a frame of the bag on the curb - just one - because she doesn't want to forget the exact moment the fantasy turned to residue. Then she carries it home, not to keep it, but to prove she can survive holding something that looks beautiful and rots anyway.

Keep the Rot

Her camera's still warm from the flash

she points at the sidewalk where color used to land

now it's plain pavement, bruised gray

the kind of ground that doesn't flatter you

Imani opens the bag a crack

lets the smell hit - metal, sweet, wrong

like a promise you made while you were broke

like a smile that didn't come with protection

She shuts it again

a zipper of control around decay

she won't let the rot spill out into her day

she won't let the lesson turn into another addiction

A friend texts: "You really took the rainbow?"

She types back, deletes it, types again

"Yeah. I took the end."

"Not the wish."

"Not the shine."

"Just the rot."

She wipes her lens with a clean strip of cloth

stares through glass at what stays real

faces, corners, receipts, the hard math

the stuff that doesn't change its mind when the sun moves

The rainbow's gone from the alley

but the pattern stays in her head

glow that fades, glitter that lies, beauty that breaks on contact

She keeps walking with the bag sealed tight

because ending the chase feels like breathing

because she's learned the trick

and the trick is: take the rot, cut the spell, keep moving - no halo, no bargaining



Teach Stocks and BDS

Margin Call Gospel

The ticker's blinking like a busted neon sign, right above my sink.

Khalil, 39, financial coach, counts bills with a cracked thumbnail.

He says, "I teach stocks - then BDS shows up like a stray dog."

He drags the chair closer to the router, not the couch.

"BDS," he mutters, "that gut-check block - don't let it slide."

The chart's a street map with no street names.

Candles stack like bricks in a wall he built with shaking hands.

He scrolls, then stops - eyebrows tight, jaw wired.

"Caring?" he laughs once, like it's a joke told in court.

"I don't fold for vibes. I fold for proof."

He taps a watchlist like it owes him rent.

One stock red, one stock green, both acting brand new.

He holds his phone up to the blue light, like a receipt.

"BDS," he repeats, "means I don't buy the story."

No praying for miracles - just reading what the market did.

Then the boss text hits: "We need you to care more."

He stares at the message until the letters start to sweat.

He says, "Jimmy was wrong about caring."

Caring don't pay the spread.

Caring don't hedge.

Caring don't stop the slip when the candle breaks your plan.

He opens the memo app - Market-into-Memoir Lens, no cap.

He writes: *I learned fear from losses, not lectures.*

He writes: *I learned discipline when my chest wanted to quit.*

He writes: *If I'm teaching stocks, I'm teaching how I survived myself.*

He pulls up the order ticket, sets a limit like a boundary.

Not market - limit. Not hope - rules.

He watches the bid/ask breathe, then submits.

"BDS stays on," he says, "even when my feelings bang the door."

And the candle lands - quiet - like a verdict you can't argue with.

Limit Order Mercy

A red screen stares back, numbers cold as a steel sink.

Khalil's thumb hovers over "confirm," like a blade deciding.

He says, "If I panic, I'm just trading my mood."

He flips to the notes where he keeps the scars.

He calls it his memoir, but it reads like a war room.

BDS is his rule: block the bait, don't chase the noise.

He watches the news feed - headlines try to sell him tomorrow.

He hears Jimmy in his head, soft voice, "Just care harder."

Khalil spits, "Care doesn't fix a bad entry."

Care doesn't erase the gap between intention and execution.

He drags a chart zoom to the last 30 days.

Volume spike - then fade.

Breakout - then betrayal.

He circles it with a marker in the margin, like evidence.

"Teach stocks," he says, "teach the part nobody wants."

The part where your hands shake and you still follow the limit.

He tests himself: stop-loss at 1.5% away.

Take profit at 3% - not greedy, not scared.

He sets it clean, like locking a door before sleep.

He doesn't ask the market to forgive him.

He asks his plan to stay.

The phone buzzes again - another "opportunity" from a stranger.

Khalil's eyes narrow.

He can smell the trap through the emojis.

BDS clamps down, like a mouth closed on a secret.

He laughs, low: "That's not care. That's marketing."

He writes another line in the memo: *I turned pain into rules.*

He adds: *I stopped treating losses like destiny.*

He adds: *I started treating them like tuition.*

Then he hits confirm, and the screen moves.

Not magic - movement.

Not comfort - control.

Bid Ask Bruises

The bid's sitting lower, the ask's acting slick.

Khalil watches the spread widen like a grin that costs money.

He says, "Stocks got manners - until you get greedy."

He scrolls his old trades, dates lined like receipts.

He sees the one where he didn't respect BDS.

He sees the one where he chased a green candle like a fist fight.

Jimmy told him, "If it feels right, it is right."

Khalil shook his head then.

Khalil shakes it now.

"Feeling right is how you get buried," he says.

He taps "shares" and it clicks into place - numbers don't lie.

He taps "avg cost" and it drags the past behind him.

He opens the Market-into-Memoir Lens again.

He writes the date, then the lesson.

Not poetic for show - poetic like a bruise you press to remember.

I wanted to care my way out.

I wanted the market to be kind.

It wasn't.

So he teaches himself to translate pain into practice.

He sets an alert when price hits the prior support.

He sets another when it breaks - no arguing with physics.

He's not "manifesting."

He's measuring.

He's timing.

He's refusing to be hypnotized by a bounce.

A comment pops up under his post: "You don't care enough."

Khalil reads it twice, then deletes nothing.

He just moves different.

He writes in the memo: *Caring can be a cover story.*

Sometimes caring is just you avoiding accountability.

BDS, he thinks, is accountability with teeth.

He checks the order book: thin liquidity, shaky steps.

He pauses - then cancels the trade he wanted to force.

That pause is the whole point.

That pause is where his old self tries to scream.

And he lets it scream without letting it drive.

He looks at the next setup, cleaner.

He enters with a smaller size - half what he used to.

He says, "I'm not trying to win every day."

He's trying to survive long enough to teach the next one.

Survival is the first verse.

Candle Therapy

The screen shows a doji - half promise, half warning.

Khalil's face goes still like he just heard a threat.

He says, "That's not a sign. That's indecision."

He keeps the cursor still, like stillness is discipline.

He won't turn indecision into impulse.

BDS locks the temptation in a cage.

He thinks about Jimmy again, always "care more," "be softer."

Khalil answers with action, not debate.

He pulls up his checklist in the memo - no fluff, just gates.

Is the trend aligned?

Is the level respected?

Is the risk defined?

Is the position size sane?

He doesn't say it out loud, but it beats in his chest.

His pain used to come out as noise - buying, selling, panicking.

Now it comes out as a method.

Market-into-Memoir Lens: pain becomes a rule, not a rumor.

He writes: *I stopped praying for reversals.*

I started demanding confirmation.

The candle flips - then stutters.

He waits through the shake, watches it hold.

He sets a stop-loss at the swing low, not his ego.

He sets take profit at the next resistance, not his fantasy.

He's not trying to win a headline.

He's trying to keep his account alive.

His phone rings - somebody he coached before.

They say, "You changed. You got cold."

Khalil stares at the ring, then lets it go to voicemail.

"Cold?" he says in the memo.

"Cold is what keeps the brain from burning."

Warm is what gets you emotional and careless.

He sees the next green candle form - slow, respectful.

He enters like he's signing a contract with his future.

He exhales when it breaks his trigger.

Then he logs it: entry, reason, outcome.

He doesn't just trade - he records the truth.

Pain tried to become a monster.

He taught it to become a guardrail.

That's the whole therapy: practice with receipts.

Golden Mask Spread

A gold mask hangs on the wall like a dare.

Khalil rubs the edge of it, then goes back to the screen.

He says, "My feelings don't get voting rights."

The chart's moving - slow at first, then aggressive.

The volume jumps like it's trying to scare him into rushing.

He feels the urge anyway: jump in, chase the surge, prove something.

BDS slams the door.

He hears Jimmy's voice - "care more" - like a broken siren.

Khalil snaps, "Caring is cute until it wrecks the plan."

He opens the memo app and writes the old pattern.

I mistook urgency for opportunity.

I mistook panic for instinct.

I mistook attention for discipline.

He draws a level with the bluntest tool he has: a horizontal line.

He measures risk in dollars, not hope.

He sizes the position to survive a wrong day.

He sets the stop at 1.2% - tighter than his ego wants.

He sets the take profit at 2.8% - realistic, not greedy.

He doesn't brag - he executes.

The candle wicks up, then rejects.

His stop stays put, like a soldier holding his post.

He watches it hit without flinching, because flinching is for street fights.

This is numbers.

This is consequences.

This is the lesson paying itself.

He logs the loss, then logs the why.

Market-into-Memoir Lens again - pain translated into practice.

He writes: *I didn't quit.*

He writes: *I didn't chase.*

He writes: *I respected BDS even when it felt mean.*

A new setup appears - cleaner structure, clearer level.

He enters smaller, waits for confirmation, lets the market talk.

He says, "I'm not teaching stocks with fake confidence."

He's teaching them with scars that learned to behave.

The gold mask stays on the wall.

The method stays on the screen.



Change Constant Is Change²

Slide Rule

Why does the same mistake hit different every time it comes back?

A receipt printer coughs out a new date stamp

like the world got bored with yesterday

and changed the lock mid-breath

Last time I let you slide - you smiled like friction was optional

then slipped my name into your mouth

Grace, 35, school librarian

fingers ink-stained from stamping returns

hears the corner of a paperback snap

like a rule bending under weight

“Don’t,” she says, not pretty - practical

“Last time you lied, I still shelved it”

The barcode scanner screams a refusal

because the book’s status flipped overnight

OFF-SITE to HERE again to OFF-SITE

like a bad decision on a loop

She lines up spines by Dewey, steady hands

but her chest keeps count in a different math

the slip that hurt is still in the groove

You want consistency?

Use the constant-change drill

change the brace before you need it

change the key before the door decides

She grabs a laminated index card from the desk drawer

HALF-PAST DUE / FULL-PAIN RETURN

and writes the new consequence in bold

"Time's moving," you say, casual as a coin toss

Grace answers with a stamp that thuds

THIRD NOTICE / FINAL NOTICE / LAST CHANCE

The hallway clock stutters - second hand skips like it's ashamed to be seen

and the air feels thinner, meaner

like a policy got updated without asking

"Last time you let me slide," you whisper

but your voice trips over the same syllables

the slip that hurt is still in the carpet glue

She walks to the circulation desk

and swaps the old keycard sleeve

for a fresh one with a different strip number

New week, same teeth

new policy, same consequences

new version of you, still trying to reroute the blame

Grace doesn't ask for mercy anymore - she drills the moment into something
survivable

then watches the door refuse you clean

Because change is the only thing that never clocks out

and if you don't practice the shift

you'll get shifted anyway

Change Drill

The barcode blinks red, the day won't stay the same,

Last time you slid, I shelved your excuse in line;

Now status flips - return to sender, no flame,

The slip that hurt still stains the shelf like brine.

Grace stamps the due date, then stamps it again,

A new keycard sleeve, a strip number that's new;

You say "it's different," like that makes it harmless, friend,

But consequences travel faster than you do.

The printer spits a fresh form, thin and mean,

Third notice, final notice, final-final ink;

You try to talk smooth, but the numbers keep gleam,

They don't care if you're sorry or if you think.

Change is the only god that doesn't ask.

I drill the shift, so you can't move the task.

Dewey Pivot

Barcode red again

Grace stamps the due date - keys change, not the hurt

Third Notice

Paper rustles tight

last time you slid - policy

turns the page on you

Keycard Shift

New strip, same desk

the lock learns a different

angle for your lies

Shelf Pressure

Spines stand in rows

yet one slip makes the whole

system tilt, then stand

Final Return

Final notice bites

still the calculator hums - change keeps score, loud

Constant-Change Drill

You want the same door twice, I get it - but the hinge don't care what you prefer, it moves.

Last time you let me slide, you acted clever,
then the slip that hurt taught gravity to prove.

Grace, 35, librarian hands steady - stamp thud, scanner buzz, the status flips again.

You reach for loopholes like they're candy,
but the code updates while you call it "fair."

Last time you let me slide, you acted clever,
the slip that hurt still lives in my thumbprint.

The third notice shows up like a hammer,
final notice writes itself where your excuses sit.

You talk like time owes you a favor,
but time don't sign your name, it signs its own.

Grace drills the constant-change - no savior,
change is the only thing that stays unowned.

Last time you let me slide, you acted clever,
so when the lock shifts, you don't get to pretend.

The slip that hurt becomes the drill I carry - and every new version of you gets bent.

Last time you let me slide, you acted clever,

the slip that hurt - now watch me change the rules, then leave you.



Choose Air Conditioned Love

“Keep it cool, keep it clean.”

“Heat don’t mean love.”

Benji got the window unit humming like it’s got a job.

He says, “Don’t hit my inbox with thirst - turn your temp down first, then talk.”

He been burnt by screen-glow romance,

the kind that sells skin in installments and never sweats consequences.

He don’t want “OnlyFans” as a personality - he wants a woman who can hold a steady room.

Cooling your mind before intimacy,

that’s not a slogan, it’s a survival skill:

filters changed, vents unblocked, attitude not stuck on blast.

He tests the air like it matters - because it does - and when the room finally settles,

the conversation stops shaking.

Chiller Requirements

Need a woman who cools her own chaos before she spills it on me

Need a woman who don't sell herself like a subscription, just be solid

Need a woman who can say "I'm heated" and then fix the temperature

Need a woman who keeps her mouth from running hotter than her body

Need a woman who understands the difference between attention and intimacy

Need a woman with air conditioners, plural, not fantasies on demand

Need a woman who changes the filter like it's routine, not a flex

Need a woman who listens when the room gets loud

Need a woman who knows how to close the vent without slamming doors

Need a woman who can touch my face and not start a fire

Need a woman who don't weaponize thirst for leverage

Need a woman who respects boundaries like they're ductwork - sealed

Need a woman who keeps her tone even when her day ain't

Need a woman who can cool her mind when the past starts yelling

Need a woman who doesn't confuse dopamine with devotion

Need a woman who can stand in the cold and still stay close

Need a woman who won't make my peace feel like a crime

Condensation Map

NO HOT CHAT

NO "PAY TO LOOK"

JUST AIR

thermostat: 70°F

mood: steady

mind: filtered

☒ cool, not ☒

☒ chaotic ☒

if your thoughts run warm

I'm checking vents

I'm not ignoring smells

drip on the sill?

that's just condensation - not your whole personality

Cooling-Consent Framework

Benji wipes the coil housing with a rag that's almost black.

He watches the grime come off like confession.

"Don't ask me for affection with the temp on high," he says.

"Heat makes liars loud."

He thinks about the girls who built a whole stage outta static.

Scroll, pose, promise - then disappear when it's time to show up.

Nah.

Give me a woman who can manage the room.

Give me someone who knows what happens when the filter's clogged - air gets thick,
temp lies, everybody coughs.

She don't gotta be perfect.

She gotta be aware.

If she's stressed, she vents - not on me, not through me, not like I'm a trash can for
her rage.

Benji sets the thermostat, clicks it down one notch.

Not dramatic. Just exact.

He tells himself: consent is maintenance.

You don't "feel it" once and call it done.

You keep checking. You keep adjusting.

When the air finally steadies, he can breathe without bargaining.

When her mind's cool, her hands don't shake with ego.

When her mouth's calm, her "yes" lands clean.

If she wants intimacy, she learns the basics:

turn the heat off before you touch the switch.

He's not trying to date a livestream.

He's trying to date a person.

And a person who cools first

gives him something he can trust - a room that doesn't punish him for wanting peace.

Cold Start Love

OnlyFans heat makes my head spin, I need quiet air to think.

Air conditioners hum, minds settle, and the truth stops blinking.

If her temper climbs faster than the thermostat, I'm out before it's a mess.

Cooling your mind first - then closeness - no rushed mess, no stressed guess.

I don't fall for flashing captions; I fall for consistent conditions.

Clean filters, clear boundaries, that's the real kind of permission.

Touch me after she's steady, not while she's running hot with chaos.

Cold start love - less drama, more breath, more "yes" that don't ghost.

Keep it cool, keep it clean, let the room do what it's built for.

Because the best intimacy feels like steady HVAC - no surprises, just relief, and momentum that keeps moving forward.



Open Doors and Watch Life

Doorway Attention Practice

A greased handle, my palm slips - no one holds it.
"Ma'am, go ahead," they say, but the body stays parked.

I watch the gap widen like a mouth that don't feed.

Yvette, daycare director, keys biting her hoodie pocket.

She shoulders in with one arm, the other arm full.

A kid's mitten flops on the floor - she doesn't notice.

"Don't let it hit you," she mutters, to nobody.

Her phone lights up: doorbell footage, no help, just glare.

Someone behind her laughs, like the hinge owes them patience.

Yvette swears under her breath, then swears back at the air.

She counts seconds like bills: one, two, three - no door.

Open Hand Haikus

No one moves for her

handle cold in her palm, alone

she keeps it moving

Doorway, camera glare

Yvette clocks the angle, no blink

kid's mitten on tile

Keycard beeps, still late

a man steps past, locks the moment

life watches back

She breathes, then looks up

eyes on hinges, not on excuses

hold the next frame

Glass doors don't beg

she turns focus - doorway attention

watch life pass through

Silver Seconds

If he can hold it, he chooses not to - watch the choice.

Yvette counts the choice in the click of a latch.

A stroller wheel hits grit, and nobody lifts a brake.

She doesn't ask twice - she tracks the gap.

They say "after you," but their feet say "never."

Doorway Attention Practice: eyes on the hinge, no prayer.

Her tote swings, tags flutter, coffee spills in slow motion.

Still she catches the kid before the floor gets credit.

The footage don't lie - one hand on keys, one hand on ego.

Yvette reads the frame: respect is an action, not a rumor.

A lady's arms are full, a man's hands are empty.

He keeps them empty like a flex, like a threat.

So she widens her stance - ready for the next slammed moment.

She learns the rhythm: open doors don't grow on time.

She walks through anyway, like the hallway owed her rent.

Keep your eyes open - life passes like a train you track.

Hinged Focus Haikus

Stairwell lights buzz

somebody passes, shoulder-first

she watches the gap

Her phone shows the truth

a palm hovering, then walking off

no reach, no rescue

Mitten, lost, found fast

Yvette grabs it like a promise

life still needs hands

She sets her own pace

Doorway Attention Practice tightens

no more surprise hurt

Hinge squeaks - she smiles

not sweet, just sharp, like "try me"

watch life pass through

Open Door Pulse

No one holds the door for ladies anymore, so I measure the latch.

Yvette measures it too - like rent due, like breath due.

The kid says "look!" and points at the handle like it's a villain.

She points back with her eyes: watch the moment, don't flinch.

A man steps through first, then acts surprised at the mess.

Doorway Attention Practice turns surprise into evidence.

Her hand finds the pull before the panic finds her.

Not luck - attention. Not hope - timing.

"I said thank you," she mutters, but her voice is steel.

Because gratitude alone don't stop a slam.

Her daycare clipboard reads like a scoreboard of needs.

She can't afford to miss the doorway math again.

The door fights back with springs and stubborn weight.

She fights it back with focus - eyes wide, spine steady.

Keep your eyes open; life passes like a bus with bad brakes.

Yvette stands where it might stop, and she doesn't blink.

CHAPTER 40

Look at My Mask Golden

Jules holds the mask up to the bathroom light - brassy, mean, clean.

The gold catches every lie I ever told with my mouth.

"Don't ask," I say, and my teeth grin like a trap.

The mirror fogs where my breath lands.

The mask stays bright, like it don't sweat.

Like it don't flinch when I flinch.

My phone buzzes - no service, then sudden bars.

A message loads wrong, like the screen's got a grudge.

I laugh once, sharp, then swallow it.

I wear the gold like a receipt.

Like proof I made it through the part where I didn't.

Like armor you can't return to the store.

"Golden," the mask whispers in my skull.

"Golden," it repeats when I try to act normal.

I press my thumb to the edge - cold metal, hot memory.

Somebody on the hallway TV says my name wrong.

Somebody online posts a clip like it's gospel.

I don't argue; I tighten the strap.

Look at my mask golden - don't blink too long.

I hid my face in shine so the damage couldn't follow.

If you see me, you might see what I survived.

I shut the bathroom door on the panic.

I let the gold answer instead of me.

And when the room goes quiet, I still hear the refrain: golden.

Golden-Mask Closure

I stitch the strap with a pocketknife, blade dull but faithful - golden.

The latch clicks like a judge slamming a gavel - golden.

I sign my silence in duct-tape script on the inside of the vault - golden.

Every time they try to pry it open, the hinge stays stubborn - golden.

I keep the receipt in my wallet, crumpled, never spent - golden.

I pay in bruises, but I walk out wearing shine - golden.

I talk to my reflection like it owes me rent - golden.

It nods, then laughs, then shows me what I mean - golden.

My prayers don't rise; they bounce off the mask and land - golden.

So I don't beg the sky, I just hold the light - golden.

I leave the door half-closed for the ghosts with bad breath - golden.

They knock, I don't answer, I'm busy being proof - golden.

You can call it a mask if you need a word to sleep - golden.

Jules just calls it closure, and the night can't undo it - golden.

Don't Ask Who I Am

I turned the lock with a bent key, like the world got flimsy.

My reflection didn't ask questions - it just wore the gold back.

"Who are you?" a voice tries to crowd my throat.

I point at the mask, let it do the talking.

Don't ask.

The answer might bite.

I hear my name in other people's mouths - wrong temperature, wrong tune.

I hear my past on repeat, like a radio station stuck on static.

So I step into the light that doesn't care who I was.

Gold holds steady while everything else jitters.

My hands shake when the doorbell rings.

Not from fear - more like habit, like my body remembers.

I press the mask tighter, notch by notch.

Each click is a boundary drawn in metal ink.

Somebody wants the story like they want a refund.

I don't give receipts to strangers with open palms.

Don't ask who I am.

Ask what I survived, and I'll show you the shine.

The bathroom mirror fogs again, then clears.

The gold doesn't blur.

It stays sharp enough to cut doubt.

I walk out with a swagger made of locked rooms.

I talk with my jaw instead of my throat.

And if you still don't get it, that's your problem.

I don't owe you a face.

I owe myself a finish.

Look at the mask - then leave it alone.

Air-Conditioner Mercy

The gold mask sits on my nightstand like a pet that bites only when needed. I don't tell it secrets; it already knows my timing - how fast I fold, how fast I flare. When the world tries to label me, I keep my answers in the metal. No name, no origin story, no "explain yourself" sermon. If somebody knocks like they're owed a confession, I let the room stay quiet. The mask is closure with a price tag you can't read. It's the final rule: don't ask who I am - just look at what I did with the damage, how I turned it into something bright enough to survive your questions.

NoEmotion Release

I say "don't ask" and the air listens.

NoEmotion swells in my chest like bass through cheap walls.

The gold mask gleams - like it paid the fee.

Like it clocked out my old excuses.

My phone shows "message failed," then shows me a grin.

The screen lies; the mask don't.

I tighten the strap with two hard pulls - no softness.

If you want a villain, I can hand you one.

If you want a saint, good luck.

NoEmotion, let it ride.

The beat keeps time with my silence.

I look at my face in the mirror - then I look past it.

Past the urge to explain.

Past the need to be understood.

I'm done begging for permission.

I'm done trading my life for somebody else's comfort.

Look at my mask golden - let the shine be the proof.

Don't ask who am I, just take the truth as it comes.

NoEmotion release, I cut the cord with a grin.

Golden on my head, quiet in my hands.

Yeeaaaaahhhh

CHAPTER 41

Crackling Lincoln

my skin is crawling like Lincoln logs stacked wrong
I count the seams, they whisper names - Abraham, Isaac, Jacob
they tell me stories in splinters, holy wood lies soft as syrup
outside the motel room the TV hums nonsense about saints
inside my palm a taco-shaped mirror, I wake up, grab a brush
put a little taco on my face and laugh because prayer won't stick
I pace the linoleum, feet on the cold words of scripture
they promised pillars, gave me playthings that splinter under weight
one log blinks and says, "forgive," another says, "pay later"
I call Mr. Sacco, he don't pick up, the line is full of static saints
"Homie don't play that" - I tell the mirror, I am one of a kind
tell that bitch to give me my J's back, the shoe-box sermon gone missing
my skin remembers every sermon like a bruise under a shirt
there's a Bible verse stuck to my heel, the glue still warm from lying
I stomp, the room laughs in tongues, the Lincoln logs clap like teeth

I don't promote violence - I translate it into rhythm
the crawl under my skin becomes a beat, a cheap metronome
I tap the dresser, count the holes the lies made, measure my patience
in the corner a sack of nachos breathes like a fallen prophet
I can't make you know the taste of guilt with salsa on top
system's down, so I improvise - nachos for the Wasteland Choir
the mirror says I'm sorry, like a system reboot with no progress bar
I flip the taco, make a face, put on the mask of someone who owns his mess
the logs creak, the names smirk, and I spit a line that sounds like prayer

Glass Gospel

I lay the Lincoln logs in a circle, make a pulpit of splinters
Abraham leans, Isaac frowns, Jacob tries to steal the sermon
their lies are polished, varnished, holy-market grade deceit
a bitch wearing makeup walks across my memory, heavy with powder
she hums televangelist jingles, offers me a coupon for salvation
"Wake up, grab a brush," she coaches, like salvation's a beauty hack
my skin is a map of papery veins, I follow the subway of itch
every stop: a scandal, a rumor, a politician's hand in the cookie jar
Mr. Sacco at the corner with a Bible and a cigarette - he reads me wrong

I put a taco on my cheek to make the world laugh off the ache
the mirror trembles, repeats "sorry the system is down" like a chant
there's comfort in the admission, like a band-aid with spiritual branding
I remember childhood prayers turned into trading cards
Joe Biden at recess with a cape no one asked for - the playground whispers
they hand out raggedy shirts to Dr. Phil like charity theater
my skin crawls; I convert the itch into syllables
feed the country chicken nuggets, ba da ba ba ba - the jingle becomes a spell
I wrap the lies in brand names and swallow them like communion
the Lincoln logs agree: truth is heavy, truth snaps when you sit on it
I stand and shout into the motel vent, let the pipes carry my confession
the echo returns, friendlier now: "you've got this," it says, like a prayer in slang

Taco Mirror

I stare at the taco mirror, take inventory of every rumor stuck to me
a list: stolen J's, master Roshi fantasies, couches named Sammy, trunks named
Danny
the inventory's messy - like the back of a closet, like a mind with moths
I toast stale bread with the phrase "don't catch me slipping"
put the ladder on the table because the chair forgot its job

I forget the tables, grab the tables, measure fairness in furniture
my ovaries for a four-leaf clover - I scribble it in the margins of a receipt
G Cloverfield upside-down, the universe doing handstands for attention
I laugh so hard the taco mirror cracks a little and shows teeth
somebody's talking about donations, about charity with a footnote
they pack beanie babies in cauldrons and call it foreign policy lite
Hillary burgles metaphors, steals playgrounds, wraps it in expensive fabric
the mirror keeps the receipts: "did you bring the condoms?" the note reads
we were stupid then, the motel bed remembers every dumb move like a diary
well now you're on Dateline 2020, the headline says, but the motel is still cheap
I trace my name on the cracked glass, feel the splinter of history
my fingers tremble, say "I'm alone again" like a beat to come back to
the taco mirror answers with a wink and a suggestion: breathe, then spit

Splinter Sermon

I hold a Lincoln log to my ear like a vintage radio
the preacher's voice plays backward, "forgive" becomes "forget not to check the
locks"
Abraham, Isaac, Jacob form a chorus with bad harmonies, bless the wrongs
I make a list of names that ruined birthdays and holidays

Ted Mosby steps out of a sitcom doorway holding someone's hand he shouldn't

Danny Glover drives a narrative to the edge, asks me if we're all in America

"Don't catch me slipping" becomes a mantra and a threat

I stack ladders on chairs so the world can't reach me from below

wait, I forgot the tables - now fairness is a balancing act

my skin crawls like a playlist shuffling through guilty songs

I put drugs in the nuggets for my thugs, the jingle turns darker

it becomes a prayer for survival sung in a key the saints don't recognize

I protest with multitasking hands, feed the hungry with one fist

my left hand tosses nuggets, right hand turns off the TV that lies

it feels like writing a new gospel where credit cards are salvation

the Lincoln logs are witnesses; they creak under the weight of my truth

they whisper metrics: 3.5 inches of bone-deep ache, 2 cups of regret

they suggest a resource - a cheap incense from the corner store named Hope

you've got this, the logs say, though they sound like they don't believe me

so I climb on the table, shout a sermon that smells like grease and courage

I beg the motel to hold the echoes while I patch the mirror with tape

Golden Scratch

I keep my mask in a silver vault but tonight it leaks gold like regret

look at my mask golden - the motel light makes it honest and ugly

the scratch across the cheekline maps where truth scraped me raw

Abraham, Isaac, Jacob line the hallway in picture frames of blame

they smile politely, then lie politely, then demand apologies I can't afford

I flip the taco mirror one last time and see a face that owes nobody answers

there's a number on the nightstand: hotline, help, or a scam - depends who answers

I call and hang up twice, the system's down again, so I tell the room a secret

I say "I'm alone again" and the room returns the line, "you're not alone tonight"

I tuck the logged confessions into a sock, tie it like a headband of small victories

I put the ladder back on the floor, the chairs return to being chairs

I remember to grab the tables this time, fairness is heavy but liftable

my skin still crawls - Lincoln logs lining the throat, names on the tongue

but I pound a rhythm on the mattress, set it to a beat that says don't fold

you've got this, it whispers, a cheap pep talk with better cadence than a prayer

so I tie the taco mirror to the suitcase and walk out past the motel neon

Abraham doesn't follow, Isaac takes a detour, Jacob lingers at the light

I keep walking, mask in my pocket, splintered gospel under my soles - and I keep going

Final Thoughts

You now have everything you need to succeed with golden mask verse. The techniques and insights in this book are designed to deliver real results when you put them into practice.

As you continue experimenting, remember that mastery comes from curiosity, patience, and a willingness to try new approaches. Use these foundations as a starting point, then make them your own. The best results happen when you combine what you've learned with your unique perspective and creativity.

Start with what resonates most, build on what works, and don't be afraid to adapt along the way. Thank you for choosing this book: now go create something amazing.

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Golden Mask Verse

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First Edition: September 2026

